



CITY: PG 2

Capital records highest cybersecurity incidents



NATION: PG 5

West Asia crisis: PM Modi urges states to work as 'Team India'



FILM: PG 14

Akshay Kumar bets high on his new film 'Bhooth Bangla'

STRIKES HIT IRAN

Tehran targets Israel, Gulf states amid mixed signals over talks to end war

ASSOCIATED PRESS

DUBAI: Airstrikes battered Iran and Iranian missiles, and drones targeted Israel's Tel Aviv and sites across the Mideast on Tuesday, even as President Donald Trump said the US was in talks with the Islamic Republic to end the war.

With thousands more US Marines on their way to the Gulf, both sides firing barrages and Iran denying any negotiations are taking place, the war's tempo remained high a day after Trump delayed his self-imposed deadline for Iran to reopen the Strait of Hormuz. Tehran's chokehold on that crucial waterway has snarled international shipping, sent fuel prices skyrocketing, and threatened the world economy.

Pakistan offered to host diplomatic talks, but Iran



Palestinians inspect the wreckage of an Iranian missile that landed in the West Bank village of Kift Haris AP/PTI

remained defiant, vowing to fight "until complete victory."

Any talks between the US and Iran would face monumental challenges. Many of Washington's shifting list of

objectives — particularly over Iran's ballistic missile and nuclear programs — remain difficult to achieve. Meanwhile, it's not clear who in Iran's government would have

the authority to negotiate — or be willing to, as Israel has vowed to continue taking out leaders after killing several.

Iran remains highly suspicious of the United States,

which twice, under the Trump administration, has attacked during high-level diplomatic talks, including with the Feb. 28 strikes that started the current war. **Continued on P4**

CLOSER LOOK

» US President Donald Trump says talks underway with Iran, Tehran firmly denies negotiations

» Thousands of US Marines heading to Gulf as both sides continue heavy barrages

» Iran's Strait of Hormuz pressure disrupts shipping, pushes global oil prices above \$100

» Pakistan offers to host talks; US agrees in principle, Iran yet to be convinced

» Iranian leadership calls negotiation reports "FAKE NEWS", vows to fight until "COMPLETE VICTORY"

Quick News

HARISH RANA DIES IN INDIA'S FIRST EUTHANASIA CASE

NEW DELHI: Harish Rana, 31, passed away on Tuesday at AIIMS-Delhi following a landmark Supreme Court ruling permitting passive euthanasia. In a coma since 2013 after a tragic fall, Rana was the first in India to undergo the legal withdrawal of life support, granting him what his family called "death with dignity." **See P5**

RAJASTHAN ROYALS SET FOR RECORD \$1.63 BN SALE

NEW DELHI: Rajasthan Royals is set to be acquired by a US-based consortium led by tech entrepreneur Kal Somani for a record \$1.63 billion (approx. Rs 15,290 crore).

The group includes Walmart's Rob Walton and the Hamp family (Ford Motor Co). Pending BCCI approval, the takeover will take effect after the IPL 2026 season. **See P12**

BIRLA GROUP-LED CONSORTIUM BUYS RCB FOR \$1.78 BN

BENGALURU: A consortium led by the Aditya Birla Group (ABG) on Tuesday acquired 100 percent equity stake in IPL franchise Royal Challengers Bengaluru for a whopping USD 1.78 billion (approximately Rs 16,706 crore) from its current owner the United Spirits Limited. **See P12**

GOVT MULLS 1-HR WINDOW FOR FLAGGED CONTENT REMOVAL

NEW DELHI: The Centre is assessing whether to further tighten deadlines for removing unlawful online content, potentially reducing the current 2 to 3 hour window to just one hour, The Indian Express reported. The proposal remains at an early stage, with officials indicating that any move will depend on how social media platforms comply with existing timelines. A senior government official, speaking anonymously, said the decision would hinge on **Continued on P4**

LS passes transgender amendment bill



MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: Lok Sabha on Tuesday passed the Transgender Persons (Protection of Rights) Amendment Bill, 2026, amid opposition criticism that it excludes sexual orientations and curbs self-identification. Justice Minister Virendra Kumar said it protects those facing discrimination due to biological factors and strengthens penalties up to 14 years. Amendments were rejected, while provisions define transgender narrowly and create medical boards for identification. **See P4**

Person loses Scheduled Caste status on converting from Hinduism, Sikhism, Buddhism, says SC

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: In a ruling that clarifies the legal position on caste status and religious conversion, the Supreme Court on Tuesday held that a person from a Scheduled Caste community loses that status immediately upon converting to a religion other than Hinduism, Sikhism or Buddhism.

A bench of Justices Prashant Kumar Mishra and Manmohan upheld an April 30, 2025 order of the Andhra Pradesh High Court, which had taken a similar view in a case involving a pastor who had converted to Christianity. The court stated that the loss of Scheduled Caste status is "immediate and complete" from the moment of conversion, irrespective of birth.

Referring to Clause 3 of the Constitution (Scheduled Castes) Order, 1950, the bench said the restriction is "categorical and absolute". It noted that no individual professing a religion outside the three specified faiths can be recognised as a member of a Scheduled Caste. "Conversion to any religion not specified... results in immediate and complete loss **Continued on P4**

DGCI intensifies crackdown on unauthorised sale of weight-loss drug GLP-1

AAISHA SABIR

NEW DELHI: The Drugs Controller General of India has stepped up enforcement across the pharmaceutical supply chain to curb the unauthorised sale and promotion of GLP-1-based weight-loss drugs amid rising concerns over their misuse following the entry of multiple generic variants in the domestic market. Officials said the wider availability of these medications through retail outlets, online platforms, wholesalers and wellness clinics has heightened the risk of unsupervised consumption and off-label use.

In coordination with state drug regulators, the central authority has launched targeted inspections and audits covering online pharmacy warehouses, drug distributors, retailers and slimming centres. Over recent weeks, 49 establishments across the country were inspected to identify violations such as sale without valid prescriptions, improper dispensing practices and mislead-

PATIENT SAFETY REMAINS PARAMOUNT. THE MISUSE OF WEIGHT-LOSS DRUGS WITHOUT CLINICAL OVERSIGHT CAN LEAD TO SEVERE HEALTH COMPLICATIONS

ing promotional activities. Notices have been issued to entities found in breach of regulatory norms, with further action under consideration.

Authorities said the surge in access to GLP-1 drugs has prompted concern among health experts, who warn that using such medication without proper clinical evaluation may lead to serious adverse effects. "Patient safety remains paramount. The misuse of weight-loss drugs without clinical oversight can lead to severe health complications," the health ministry said in a statement, advising citizens to use these medicines only under qualified medical supervision. **Continued on P4**

Delhi Budget puts green push at core with 21% allocation

CM Rekha Gupta presents Rs.1,03,700-crore Delhi Budget for 2026-27



AIMAN FATIMA

NEW DELHI: Chief Minister Rekha Gupta on Tuesday presented a Rs.1,03,700-crore Budget for 2026-27 in the Delhi Assembly, outlining 10 focus areas and a strong push towards environmental sustainability, while also significantly enhancing allocations

KEY POINTS

- » Outlay rises 3.7 per cent over previous year
- » Budget structured around 10 priority sectors
- » 21 per cent allocation tagged under "green budget"
- » About Rs.22,000 crore earmarked for sustainability and pollution mitigation

» MCD gets record **Rs.11,666 crore, highest-ever support**

for local bodies.

The Budget marks a 3.7 per cent rise over last year, with Gupta stating that "every scheme was evaluated through a green lens," and announcing that "21 per cent of the total budget has been allocated for the green budget." Around Rs.22,000 crore has been earmarked for sustainability and

pollution mitigation, including Rs.300 crore specifically for pollution control measures.

Highlighting support to civic agencies, Gupta said, "For the first time, the decision has been taken to provide Rs.11,666 crore to the MCD, the highest in its history," adding that Delhi is progressing under **Continued on P4**

INDIA SUPPORTS DE-ESCALATION

Trump dials PM Modi, discusses Mideast crisis, Strait of Hormuz

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Amid Middle East tensions, US President Donald Trump spoke with Prime Minister Narendra Modi, on Tuesday with both leaders stressing the need to keep the vital Strait of Hormuz open for global shipping.

PM Modi said he had a "useful exchange" with the US President. In a post on X, he said India supports de-escalation and early restoration of peace, stressing that keeping the Strait of Hormuz open, secure and accessible is vital for global stability.

In a post on X, US Ambassador to India, Sergio Gor, also wrote: "President Donald Trump just spoke with Prime Minister Modi. They discussed the ongoing situation in the Middle East, including the importance of keeping the Strait of Hormuz open."

The telephone call was initiated by the US president, a day after he extended Washington's deadline by five days for Iran to reopen the Strait of Hormuz.

"India supports de-escalation and restoration of peace at the earliest. Ensuring that the Strait of Hormuz remains open, secure and accessible is essential for the whole world. We agreed to stay in touch regarding efforts towards peace and stability," he said.



Be prepared for challenges, impact may be long-lasting: PM Modi cautions

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Tuesday urged citizens to brace for challenges arising from the ongoing US-Iran war in West Asia, noting that its impact on energy supply chains and inflation could have long-term implications. Observing that the situation is constantly changing in West Asia, he said

its adverse effects are likely to persist for an extended time, and called upon citizens to remain prepared for every eventuality. The Prime Minister announced the constitution of seven empowered groups to deal with the potential long-term impacts of the West Asia war and urged states to work with the Centre in a 'Team India' approach to ward off the crisis. **See P5**

Govt says fuel stocks adequate, warns against panic buying

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: The government on Tuesday said India has adequate stocks of petrol, diesel and LPG and that all refineries are operating at high capacity despite disruptions linked to the Strait of Hormuz situation.

In an update on fuel availability, Sujata Sharma,

Joint Secretary in the Ministry of Petroleum and Natural Gas, said petrol pumps across the country remain fully functional, though panic buying triggered by rumours led to unusually high sales in some areas.

She urged citizens not to engage in hoarding and to rely on official information. **Continued on P4**

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OVER 21,800 ACCUSED ARRESTED

Capital records highest cybersecurity incidents as cases double nationwide

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The number of cybersecurity incidents in the country has more than doubled since 2021, with the national capital leading the way with the highest number of such cases being reported, Lok Sabha was informed on Tuesday.

In a written reply to a question by MP Daggumalla Prasada Rao, Minister of State for Home Bandi Sanjay Kumar presented data tracked by the Indian Computer Emergency Response Team (CERT-In) showing a sharp rise in cyber incidents over the past five years. "As per CERT-In, the highest number of cyber incidents reported, including from sectors, are from the National Capital Territory of Delhi," the minister said.

According to the data, cyber incidents increased from 14,02,809 in 2021 to 29,44,248 in 2025, marking a more than twofold rise.

The numbers stood at 13,91,457 in 2022, 15,92,917 in 2023 and 20,41,360 in 2024, indicating a steady upward trend after a slight dip in 2022.

On steps taken to tackle cyber threats, the ministry said CERT-In issues regular alerts and advisories and operates platforms for threat detection and information sharing. Initiatives such as the National Cyber Coordination Centre, Cyber Swachhta Kendra and



“The ministry added that ‘police’, ‘public order’ are state subjects, and states and UTs are primarily responsible for the investigation and prosecution of cyber crimes, with the Centre providing support”

the “Cyber Bharat Setu” programme are aimed at strengthening cyber security and promoting awareness across states and sectors.

The government said details on financial losses due to cyber incidents are not maintained by CERT-In.

Providing additional data till January 31, 2026, the ministry said over Rs 8,690 crore has been saved in more than 24.65 lakh complaints through the Citizen Financial Cyber Fraud Reporting and Management System (CFCFRMS). It also said the National-Digital Investigation Support Centre has assisted in over 13,417 cyber crime cases, while more than 1.51 lakh police and judicial

officers have registered on the ‘CyTrain’ platform, with over 1.42 lakh certificates issued.

The ministry further noted that more than 23.05 lakh suspect identifiers have been shared under a cyber criminal registry, helping decline transactions worth Rs 9,518.91 crore, and that over 21,857 accused have been arrested with assistance from coordination platforms.

It added that ‘police’ and ‘public order’ are state subjects, and states and Union Territories are primarily responsible for the investigation and prosecution of cyber crimes, with the Centre providing support through advisories and capacity-building measures.

Eleven nabbed for arranging mule accounts for cyber fraud network with Cambodia link: Cops

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The Delhi Police has arrested 11 suspects over involvement in a cyber fraud racket operating from Delhi and Mumbai, which allegedly duped a senior citizen here of more than Rs 22 lakh on the pretext of high returns on investment, an official said on Tuesday.

The accused were allegedly part of the larger network facilitating cyber fraud operations through mule bank accounts, and were linked to international operators, including those based in Cambodia, targeting Indian citizens, police said.

“The case was registered on November 21, 2025, at the cyber police station in southwest Delhi after a 60-year-old complainant reported being duped of Rs 22.67 lakh in an investment scam,” the officer said. The victim was lured



through a social media advertisement that misquoted the Union finance minister and promoted AI-based trading platforms, promising high returns.

After the victim registered through a link, people posing as investment advisors contacted him, and persuaded him to invest through online platforms and apps.

Police said the accused manipulated the complainant to transfer money into various accounts linked to a company. After he transferred the amount, the communication abruptly ended, making the victim suspicious.

HIGHLIGHTS

» A syndicate was operating from Rohini, Netaji Subhash Place in Delhi, where front offices were set up to open and manage mule bank accounts

» Raids were conducted at these locations, leading to the arrest of five accused, police said

» 40 phones, 92 fake SIM cards, 39 passbooks and cheque books seized

“During investigation, a team conducted money trail analysis, technical surveillance, call detail record examination and social media tracking to identify the accused. The probe revealed that a syndicate was operating from Rohini and Netaji Subhash Place in Delhi, where front offices were set up to open and manage mule bank accounts. Raids were conducted at these locations, leading to the arrest of five accused and recovery of a large number of incriminating materials,” he added.

Police seized 40 mobile phones, 92 fake SIM cards, 39 passbooks and cheque books,

27 ATM cards, four PAN cards, a laptop, a desktop, POS machines, UPI scanners and various fake documents used to open bank accounts.

“Further investigation led to the arrest of more accused involved in facilitating and supplying mule accounts. The money trail also pointed to transactions routed through multiple layers and eventually credited into a bank account in Mumbai,” he said.

Police conducted further raids in Rajasthan and Mumbai, where four more accused were apprehended. They had allegedly shifted operations from Rajasthan to Mumbai

and were engaged in procuring and supplying mule accounts to the network.

During interrogation, the accused disclosed that the mule accounts were used to channel funds for cybercriminals operating from Cambodia, who targeted Indian victims through fake investment schemes promising high returns.

Police said the syndicate used online platforms to share account details and test accounts before using them for fraudulent transactions. Further investigation is underway to identify other members of the network and trace more victims. The accused have been identified as Tajindra Singh (26), Ashish Saini (24), Shiv Dayal Singh (28), Shiva (18), Giriraj Kishore (18), Pratibha alias Payal (25), Satish (34), Ramdev Sangla (50), Praveen Kumawat (20), Deepak Mewara (35) and Trilok Chand Nayak (32).

DMRC signs MoU with INSEAD to boost metro sector capacity

ANAMTA FATIMA

NEW DELHI: The Delhi Metro Rail Corporation (DMRC) has signed a Memorandum of Understanding (MoU) with INSEAD, “The Business School for the World,” to enhance capacity building and professional excellence in the metro rail sector.

The agreement, signed on March 23, aims to strengthen learning through “participative and immersive”



approaches while deepening understanding of metro rail management from strategic, business, and customer satisfaction perspectives.

According to officials, the

MoU establishes a structured platform for the exchange of knowledge, ideas, and expertise between DMRC Academy and INSEAD’s Singapore campus. The collaboration is expected to combine DMRC’s operational experience in urban transport systems with INSEAD’s global academic expertise in leadership, strategy, and management education.

The initiative reflects a shared commitment to advancing skills and promot-

ing innovation in metro rail systems, while also enabling the adoption of global best practices. Officials said the partnership will contribute to the continued growth and modernisation of urban transportation infrastructure in India.

The MoU was signed by Ghansham Bansal, Director General of DMRC Academy, and Professor Sameer Hasija, Dean of Executive Education and Asia Campus at INSEAD Singapore.

Gzb: Man kills wife, her suspected lover & flees

DIPIKA KIROLA

GHAZIABAD: A man allegedly killed his wife and her suspected lover in the Tronica City area of Ghaziabad late on Monday night and fled the scene, police said.

The deceased have been identified as Shabnam (36) and Faheem (32). Shabnam was the wife of the accused, Rashid, while Faheem was reportedly his friend. The incident occurred in the Buddha Bazaar locality.

Police received a call on Dial 112 at around 12.40 am reporting a violent dispute at a residence. On reaching the spot, officers found the bodies of Shabnam and Faheem inside the house with severe head injuries.

Preliminary investigation suggests that Faheem had come to meet Shabnam at her residence during the night. Rashid allegedly returned home and found them together, leading to a heated argument. In a fit of rage, he is said to have attacked both with a heavy object, killing them on the spot, before fleeing.

Deputy Commissioner of Police (Rural) Surendra Nath

KEY POINTS

» Police received a call on Dial 112 at around 12.40 am reporting a violent dispute at a residence. On reaching the spot, officers found bodies of Shabnam and Faheem inside the house with severe head injuries

» Preliminary investigation suggests that Faheem had come to meet Shabnam at her residence during the night. Police

» Rashid allegedly returned home and found them. In a fit of rage, he is said to have attacked both with a heavy object, killing them: Police

Tiwari said three teams have been formed to trace and arrest the accused. Statements of family members are being recorded as part of the investigation.

A forensic team has inspected the scene, and the bodies have been sent for post-mortem examination. Further legal proceedings are underway, police said.

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The NHRC on Tuesday said it has issued a notice to the Delhi government and the city’s police chief over the death of nine members of a family in a fire incident in Palam area earlier this month, and sought a detailed report on it in two weeks.

Reportedly, the fire brigade teams’ hydraulic crane allegedly “developed some technical snag” resulting in delayed rescue operation. Locals have said that timely functioning of the equipment could have saved more lives, the National Human Rights Commission said in a statement.

A 70-year-old woman and three young girls -- one just three years old, of the family were killed in the massive fire that tore through a four-storey residential building in southwest Delhi’s Palam area on March 18 morning.

The NHRC said it has taken suo motu cognisance of a media report that nine members of a family died and three others sustained injuries in the fire.

The Commission has observed that the content of



“It has issued notices to chief secretary and commissioner of police of Delhi, seeking a detailed report on it within two weeks”

the news report, if true, raise a serious issue of violation of human rights.

Therefore, it has issued notices to the chief secretary and the commissioner of police of Delhi, seeking a detailed report on it within two weeks. It is expected to include the status of compensation disbursement to the aggrieved and the injured persons, the statement said.

According to the media

report, carried on March 19, the fire started around 6:15 am, allegedly due to short circuit. It started from a shop on the ground floor and quickly spread to the residential floors above.

Reportedly, the locals tried to rescue the trapped persons by breaking windows and walls of the house. A few got injured while they were reportedly trying to escape or rescue others, it said.

Bharti Ngr park to get modern makeover, work begins: NDMC

ANAMTA FATIMA

NEW DELHI: The New Delhi Municipal Council on initiated the redevelopment of a neighbourhood park in Bharti Nagar, with a focus on promoting fitness and community recreation. The foundation stone for the project was laid by NDMC Vice Chairperson Kuljeet Singh Chahal.

The project, aligned with the vision of Viksit Bharat @2047 and the Fit India Movement, aims to transform the existing park into a modern recreational space equipped with high-end amenities.

The park, located between Gate No. 3 and Gate No. 4 of Bharti Nagar Colony, will cater to residents with facilities designed to encourage physical activity and



community engagement.

According to officials, the redevelopment plan includes an EPDM-based running and walking track spread across approximately 925 square metres, along with a dedicated sports zone featuring PU flooring over nearly 290 square metres. A combined badminton and basketball court will also be constructed as part of the project.

In addition, the park will house an open-air gym and a covered gym with three-side glass walls, alongside children’s play areas and relaxation zones equipped with seating benches and pergolas. Fitness equipment such as air walkers, log cycles, and multi-station gym units are also planned to be installed.

The total cost of the project is estimated at around ₹93

“The total cost of the project is estimated at around Rs 93 lakh, with completion targeted by June 18, 2026”

lakh, with completion targeted by June 18, 2026. Landscaping and horticultural enhancements will further improve the park’s aesthetic appeal.

Chahal said the initiative reflects NDMC’s commitment to strengthening urban infrastructure while fostering healthier lifestyles. He added that such projects are key to building greener, more inclusive public spaces for residents.

Six arrested in Sangam Vihar road rage case

NEW DELHI: Six persons have been arrested in connection with a road rage incident in south Delhi’s Sangam Vihar on March 23, where a motorcyclist and his associates allegedly assaulted a Faridabad family and damaged their car. The group, travelling towards Kalkaji, had been diverted into G-Block due to road repairs when a dispute over right of way escalated into violence.

The incident was captured on video and widely circulated on X, drawing attention. Two persons, including Rampal, sustained minor injuries and were discharged after treatment. Police registered a case and identified the accused through video analysis and local inquiries. All those seen in the footage are now in custody.

YEIDA allots land to firms for tractor, food processing units

Proximity to Noida Int’l Airport seen as key factor

DIPIKA KIROLA

NOIDA: Acting on the directions of Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath, the Yamuna Expressway Industrial Development Authority (YEIDA) has allotted land to three companies for setting up manufacturing units along the Yamuna Expressway corridor, officials said. The move is aimed at accelerating industrial growth in western Uttar Pradesh, a region witnessing rapid infrastructure development and rising investor interest.

Escorts Kubota Limited has been allotted 154 acres in Sector 10 to set up a manufacturing unit for tractors and construction equipment. The project is expected to attract an



investment of around Rs 2,029 crore and generate employment for nearly 4,000 people.

Similarly, CNH Industrial India Pvt. Ltd. has been allotted 100 acres in Sector 8D for a manufacturing facility for tractors and related machinery. The project is likely to bring in an investment of over Rs 1,200 crore and create around 1,200 jobs. In another allotment, Sun Organic Industries Pvt. Ltd. has been given 30,000

Thousands of jobs likely to be generated in region

square metres in Sector 8D to set up a dry fruit processing and packaging unit. The project is expected to involve an investment of about Rs 225 crore and generate more than 500 jobs.

Officials said the allotments reflect growing investor confidence in the region, which is emerging as a key industrial hub, particularly with major infrastructure projects such as the Noida International Airport coming up nearby.

AMID OPPN OVER EXCLUSION OF GAYS, LESBIANS

LS passes transgender amendment Bill

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The Lok Sabha on Tuesday passed a Bill to amend a law on protection and rights of transgender persons, even as Opposition members raised concerns that the proposed legislation excludes social orientations from the ambit of the statute.

Responding to the debate on the Transgender Persons (Protection of Rights) Amendment Bill, 2026, Social Justice and Empowerment Minister Virendra Kumar said the proposed legislation aims to provide protection to only those who face boycott due to biological issues.

He asserted that the amendment will ensure that transgender persons continue to get legal recognition and protection.

Kumar said while the 2019 law had a provision for a maximum of two years of imprisonment, the amendment bill provides for a maximum of 14 years in jail with a penalty.

Before the passage of the Bill, the House also rejected amendments moved by Opposition members by a voice vote.

While the government said the objective is to provide protection to such persons, the opposition slammed the proposed legislation for taking away the right to self-determination of identity, such as gay and lesbian individuals, and demanded that it be sent to a



standing committee for proper consultations.

The bill seeks to give a precise definition of the term "transgender" and exclude "different sexual orientations and self-perceived sexual identities" from the ambit of the proposed law, which was introduced in the Lok Sabha earlier this month.

It underlines that a transgender person "shall not include, nor shall ever have been so included, persons with different sexual orientations and self-perceived sexual identities."

"The intent, object and purpose of the Act is and was to protect a specified class of per-

sons socially and culturally known as transgender people who face societal discrimination of an extreme and oppressive nature.

"The purpose was and is not to protect each and every class of persons with various gender identities, self-perceived sex/gender identities or gender fluidities," the bill says.

The bill notes that it is imperative to give a precise definition for proper and definitive identification and protection of transgender persons, to whom the benefits of the present law must reach.

The bill also contains provisions for "designation of authority", which will have the

HIGHLIGHTS

» Before the passage of the Bill, the House also rejected amendments moved by Oppn members by a voice vote

» While the govt said the objective is to provide protection to such persons, the opposition slammed the proposed legislation for taking away the right to self-determination of identity, such as gay and lesbian individuals, and demanded that it be sent to a standing committee for proper consultations

option to seek "expert advice" if required.

A new clause defines "authority" as a medical board headed by a chief medical officer or a deputy chief medical officer appointed by the central government, state government or a Union territory administration.

"It is affirmed that dignity, bodily autonomy, identity are protected under Article 14, 15, 19 and 21 of the Constitution," she said.

The Congress MP criticised the provision of bringing a medical board for identity determination and claimed that the bill narrows the definition of transgender.

as 'kinner', 'hijra', 'aravani' and 'jogta', or eunuch, or a person with intersex variations or a person who, at birth, has a congenital variation in one or more sex characteristics as compared to male or female.

The bill proposes to create specific offences with graded punishments that reflect the gravity of the harm, the irreversibility of the injury, and the particular vulnerability of child victims.

Earlier, participating in the debate, Congress MP Jyothimani said the bill has been brought without consultations from transgender people and shows the government's "calious" attitude.

She said Leader of Opposition Rahul Gandhi and Congress MP Priyanka Gandhi have listened to transgender people and deeply understand what they feel.

Jyothimani asserted that this bill is not a reform.

A Supreme Court judgement has recognised that gender identity is a matter of self-determination.

"It is affirmed that dignity, bodily autonomy, identity are protected under Article 14, 15, 19 and 21 of the Constitution," she said.

The Congress MP criticised the provision of bringing a medical board for identity determination and claimed that the bill narrows the definition of transgender.

"This is not democracy but

a monologue of power, which is the trademark of the Modi government," Jyothimani alleged.

The bill must be referred to a standing committee for comprehensive consultations with the transgender people, she asserted.

Samajwadi Party's Anand Bhadauria also opposed the proposed legislation and asked if the bill is for the welfare of transgender people, as the government claims, then why are they opposing this bill on the streets.

He pointed out that it was the SP that established the 'Samajwadi kinnar sabha' within its organisational ambit.

"The BJP wants to make people stand in queue. Now, you want to make transgender people stand in line for their identity," he said, adding that the bill gives a limited definition of transgender people.

"It is unfair exclusion and is not based on constitutional principles," he said.

DMK's T Sumathy also slammed the government for allegedly interfering with the right to self-determination of identity.

"This government treats the transgender community as subjects to be corrected, which is highly condemnable... the DMK rejects the bill. The government should withdraw the bill and at the least send it to the standing committee of Parliament," she said, calling the bill "draconian".

MP: Doctor arrested for raping woman on pretext of treating her

INDORE: Police have arrested a doctor in Madhya Pradesh's Indore district for allegedly raping a 30-year-old woman under the pretext of providing treatment and threatening her with obscene photographs, an official said on Tuesday.

Following the doctor's arrest on Sunday, a group of people vandalised his house and set it on fire, he said.

In the wake of the public outrage, the police and the administration took action at various levels against the doctor, including sealing his clinic, he said.

As per the FIR filed at the Badgonda police station on the night of March 22, the woman alleged that she had gone to the clinic of local doctor Shahid alias Saeed Khan three to four months ago complaining of stomach pain, Deputy Superintendent of Police (DSP) Umakant Chaudhary said.

She alleged that he raped her after administering an injection and took objectionable photographs of her, he said.

The victim claimed that the doctor had been harassing her by threatening to make the photographs public, and also said that he lured her to a resort in the Patalpani area, where he raped her again, Chaudhary said.

Khan was arrested based on the woman's complaint under relevant provisions of

the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita (BNS) and the Madhya Pradesh Freedom of Religion Act, 2021.

"Following the arrest of the accused, a group of people entered his house, vandalised it, and set the door (of the house) and motorcycle on fire," the DSP said.

He said that a case has been registered at the Mhow police station under relevant provisions based on a complaint lodged by a relative of Khan.

Additional Superintendent of Police Rupesh Dwivedi said that the accused doctor has a degree in electrohomeopathy.

Three persons have been arrested for vandalising and setting fire to the house of the accused, while a search is underway for others involved in it.

A group of right-wing activists and villagers protested the police action, and said the FIR over vandalism and arson at the doctor's house was based on a false story. The protesters also staged a road blockade in the Kishanganj area on Monday over the issue.

Ram Dangi, who led the protesters, claimed that the rape accused's family had conspired to file a false complaint against the villagers by fabricating the story of vandalism and arson.

Meanwhile, officials said Khan's alleged illegal clinic in Gujarkheda, Mhow, has been sealed. AGENCIES

Gujarat assembly passes UCC Bill; live-in relationship registration made mandatory

GANDHINAGAR: After a marathon debate of more than seven hours, the Gujarat assembly on Tuesday passed the Uniform Civil Code (UCC) Bill that seeks to put in place a common legal framework to govern marriage, divorce, succession and live-in relationships irrespective of religion.

The bill stipulates 7 years of jail term if marriages are conducted through force, coercion, or fraud, and also prohibits bigamy/polygamy. It also makes registration of marriages and live-in relationships mandatory.

The ruling BJP hailed the bill, which exempts tribals, as a landmark reform to ensure equality, while the Congress vehemently opposed it saying it violates fundamental right and was "anti-Muslim".

The bill was passed with majority voice vote as opposition Congress and Aam Aadmi Party (AAP) did not approve it and demanded that it be sent to the state assembly's select committee.

Chief Minister Bhupendra Patel, who tabled the bill earlier in the day, a week after a state-appointed panel submitted its final report on implementation of the UCC, said there is punishment of up to 7 years of jail if marriages are conducted through force, coercion, or fraud, and also in cases of bigamy/polygamy.

With the passage of the bill, BJP-ruled Gujarat became the second state in the country after Uttarakhand to pass the UCC. Uttarakhand became the first state to pass a UCC Bill in February 2024.

Titled the 'Gujarat Uniform Civil Code, 2026', the proposed law will extend to the entire state and also apply to residents of Gujarat living outside its territorial limits.

However, the bill document states that the code will not apply to members of Scheduled Tribes (ST) and certain groups whose customary rights are protected under the Constitution.

The bill aims to create a uniform legal framework, as per its

"Objects and Reasons" statement.

While tabling the bill, CM Patel described it as a step towards a unified legal framework rooted in constitutional principles.

"A common legal framework is necessary for a united and undivided nation, and that reflects our Vedic knowledge. Our ancient verses also say that the truth is one, even if expressed in different ways; and if the truth is one, then even if religions are many, justice must be one," Patel said.

Referring to the Constitution of India, he added, "Under Article 14 of the Constitution, equality before the law has been ensured for every citizen of the country. And Article 44 of that same Constitution directs the state to move towards a Uniform Civil Code. Now, the implementation of the UCC will reject any policy or dispute involving division or discrimination among citizens based on their religion or caste."

The CM said the legislation

would apply uniformly to all citizens, and reflects "the expectations, aspirations, and desires of the citizens of Gujarat for equal justice."

He emphasised that the bill introduces "a uniform legal framework" on issues like marriage, divorce, and inherited property, ensuring that no injustice is done to anyone", adding that it was drafted after "intensive discussions and deliberations" keeping in mind Gujarat's diversity.

Particularly, women's honour, equal rights, and security have been prioritised in this draft, he said.

Detailing provisions, Patel said, "Mandatory registration of marriages, registration of live-in relationships, uniform rules for divorce, equal inheritance rights for daughters and sons, and strict enforcement along with penalty provisions for non-compliance are the key provisions of this bill."

"If mandatory marriage registration is not done within 60 days, there is a fine of up to Rs

10,000. If marriages are conducted through force, coercion, or fraud, there is a punishment of up to 7 years of jail, and in cases of bigamy/polygamy, there is also a punishment of up to 7 years of jail," he said.

Talking about live-in relationships, he said, "Its registration is mandatory, and non-registration carries an imprisonment of up to 3 months or a fine of Rs 10,000. Live-in registration is not meant to snatch anyone's freedom, but for the legal protection of our daughters."

He also clarified that "absolutely no interference is being made in religious rituals".

This UCC law is solely to eliminate discrimination, not to erase cultures, he said, adding that Scheduled Tribes have been "completely exempted".

Supporting the bill, Deputy Chief Minister Harsh Sanghavi cited global and domestic examples to justify the move.

Taking a swipe at the Congress, he said, "I am not surprised at all by this response of

Congress. when Dr Babasaheb Ambedkar brought a law to give equal rights to women, the Congress government also made the same excuse that 'the time is not ripe', fed up with the same anti-women mentality, Babasaheb had to resign."

Senior Congress MLA Shailesh Parmar said, "You brought this bill in a haste in view of the upcoming assembly election in 2027. We demand that it should be sent to assembly's select committee."

Another senior Congress MLA Amit Chavda alleged that the bill violates constitutional guarantees.

Congress MLA Imran Khedawala strongly objected, saying, "I am speaking on behalf of my community and I oppose this bill because it seeks to disturb our shariat and Quran. For Muslims, matters related to nikah and inheritance are not just rules, but Allah's order and we are bound to follow it. We will stage protests and also approach court against this bill."

IT ministry issues SOP to curb non-consensual intimate imagery online

SHIMLA: The Ministry of Electronics and Information Technology has issued a standard operating procedure to prevent and control the dissemination of non-consensual intimate imagery (NCII) content under the IT Rules, 2021, an official said on Tuesday.

NCII content includes material exposing private parts, full or partial nudity, depiction of sexual acts or morphed images, and constitutes a serious violation of privacy and dignity, a statement issued here said.

According to a spokesperson of the state, Digital Technologies and Governance, multiple reporting mecha-

nisms have been put in place to support victims. Those affected can approach One Stop Centres for assistance or report such content directly on social media platforms using reporting tools or by contacting grievance officers. Incidents can also be reported through the National Cyber Crime Reporting Portal or by calling the cybercrime helpline number 1930, he said.

Victims may also lodge complaints at the nearest police station for legal action.

The official urged citizens to remain vigilant and avoid sharing such content, and to report instances promptly to ensure timely action and protection of privacy. AGENCIES

From Page 1 Tehran targets

In a related development, Pakistan's Prime Minister Shehbaz Sharif wrote on X that his country is ready to "facilitate meaningful and conclusive talks" to end the Iran war.

The US had agreed "in principle" to join talks in Pakistan, according to three Pakistani officials, one Egyptian official and a Gulf diplomat, while mediators were still working to convince Iran. The Pakistani officials said the "quiet diplomacy" had grown more complicated since news of it leaked.

Iranian Foreign Minister Abbas Araghchi's office said he has been talking about the war this week with his counterparts in several countries. But Iranian Parliament Speaker Mohammad Bagher Qalibaf called the idea of negotiations "fake news" — and the spokesman of Iran's top military command issued a newly defiant statement.

"Iran's powerful armed forces are proud, victorious and steadfast in defending Iran's integrity, and this path will continue until complete victory," Iranian state television quoted Maj. Gen. Ali Abdo-lahi Aliabadi, as saying on Tuesday.

Aliabadi did not say what victory would look like, but Iran's military could be trying to warn against offering concessions in any possible negotiations.

The Egyptian official said efforts are centred on "trust-building" between the US and Iran, with the aim of bringing about a pause in fighting. Israel is not involved.

The official, who is involved in

the efforts, said the priority is to prevent attacks on both Iran's and Gulf Arab countries' energy infrastructure and that they were working on a "mechanism" for Iran to reopen the Strait of Hormuz.

Talk of negotiations briefly drove down oil prices and boosted stocks. But that respite was short-lived, with the price of Brent crude, the international standard, nudging back over USD 100 a barrel Tuesday, up nearly 40 per cent since the war started.

Israel said it carried out an extensive series of strikes on Iranian "production sites," without providing more information. In Tehran, a massive blast was heard in northern neighbourhoods and another in the city centre.

Iran also fired multiple waves of missiles at Israel.

In Tel Aviv, a missile with a 100-kilogram warhead slammed into a street in the city centre, blowing out windows of an apartment building and sending smoke billowing. Four people suffered minor wounds.

In Kuwait, power lines were hit by air defence shrapnel, causing partial electricity outages for several hours. Bahrain said it was attacked with missiles and drones, the United Arab Emirates said air defence systems responded to similar attacks, and Saudi Arabia said it destroyed Iranian drones targeting its oil-rich Eastern Province.

Israel pounded Beirut's southern suburbs, saying that it was targeting infrastructure used by the Iran-linked Hezbollah militant group.

Meanwhile, Lebanon declared Iran's ambassador persona non grata and ordered him to leave by Sunday. The dramatic move offers the latest evidence of the deterioration in relations between Lebanon and Iran. Iranian flights have been

banned from landing in Lebanon, out of fear that they would carry weapons or funding for Hezbollah, and some top Lebanese government officials have been critical of Tehran's role in the country, accusing it of dragging Lebanon into another war with Israel.

Authorities say Israeli strikes have killed more than 1,000 people in Lebanon and displaced more than one million.

Iran's death toll has surpassed 1,500, its Health Ministry has said. In Israel, 15 people have been killed. At least 13 US military members have been killed, along with more than a dozen civilians, in the occupied West Bank and Gulf Arab states.

Govt says fuel stocks

Sharma said domestic LPG production has been stepped up, with no reported dry-outs at distributorships, even as supply remains under pressure due to the prevailing geopolitical situation. Deliveries continue as normal, she added.

Natural gas supplies to priority segments such as domestic PNG and CNG transport remain fully protected, while supplies to industrial and commercial users are being maintained at about 80 per cent of average consumption.

The government is pushing a shift from LPG to piped natural gas (PNG), with city gas companies accelerating connections and over 7,500 new domestic and commercial PNG links activated in the past day. States have been urged to expedite approvals for expanding city gas distribution networks.

To ease supply constraints,

additional allocations of commercial LPG and kerosene have been made, while alternative fuels such as coal are also being made available for small and medium consumers.

The Centre, she said, has asked states to step up enforcement against hoarding and black marketing under the Essential Commodities Act, with around 3,400 raids conducted, 642 FIRs registered and about 155 arrests made so far.

Advising restraint, the government called on citizens to avoid panic purchases, use fuel judiciously and consider alternatives such as PNG and electric cooking options during the ongoing crisis.

Person loses Scheduled

of Scheduled Caste status," the judgment said.

The court added that such a loss also leads to the automatic termination of all benefits linked to that status, including reservations, protections and statutory entitlements.

The bench examined the legislative background of the 1950 Order, pointing out that it originally applied only to Hindus. It was later extended to Sikhs in 1956 and Buddhists in 1990. "It is important to note that Christianity has not been included under this Order by any of these amendments," the court observed, adding that Christianity does not recognise caste in its theological framework.

The judgment also addressed claims related to Scheduled Tribe status, stating that continued eligibility depends on whether a person retains the customs, ritu-

als and traits of the tribe. If, over time, a convert fully abandons these practices and assimilates into another religion, they may no longer be considered part of that tribe. Such determinations, the court said, are questions of fact to be assessed during trial.

Justice Mishra, who authored the verdict, said a person cannot simultaneously profess a religion outside those listed in the 1950 Order and claim Scheduled Caste membership. He noted that adopting another religion for personal, social or spiritual reasons bars an individual from asserting such status for legal benefits. The court also laid down conditions for those seeking to regain Scheduled Caste status after reconversion. It said individuals must prove their original caste identity under the 1950 Order, establish genuine reconversion, and demonstrate acceptance by their original community. "Mere self-proclamation is insufficient," the bench said, adding that recognition by the community is essential.

The case arose from a criminal complaint filed in 2021 by Chinthada Anand, who had converted to Christianity and was serving as a pastor. He alleged that Akkala Rami Reddy and others assaulted him while he was conducting Sunday prayers in a village. Anand had invoked provisions of the SC/ST (Prevention of Atrocities) Act.

The Andhra Pradesh High Court had quashed the charges, ruling that Anand, having converted and actively practising Christianity, could not claim Scheduled Caste status. Challenging this, he approached the Supreme Court, which has now affirmed the high court's decision.

DGCI intensifies

Earlier, on March 10, the regulator issued a detailed advisory to manufacturers banning surrogate advertising and indirect promotion that could mislead consumers or encourage inappropriate usage. Officials reiterated that these drugs are approved in India under strict conditions and must be prescribed only by specialists such as endocrinologists and internal medicine physicians, and in certain cases cardiologists.

Regulators indicated that surveillance will continue in the coming weeks, with possible penalties including licence cancellations, fines and prosecution for violations.

Govt mulls 1-hr window

"the compliance track record of social media companies with the recently implemented 2-3 hour time window". No final decision has been taken, and authorities may opt not to proceed.

The current rules stem from February amendments to the Information Technology (Intermediary Guidelines and Digital Media Ethics Code) Rules, 2021, which sharply reduced earlier response times of 24 to 36 hours. Platforms must now act within three hours for most unlawful content and two hours for non-consensual intimate imagery, among the strictest timelines globally.

Alongside faster takedowns, the government is considering expand-

ing blocking powers under Section 69A beyond the IT Ministry to other key ministries. Additional measures include strengthening enforcement through the Sahyog portal and revisiting definitions of "obscene" content.

While officials maintain the focus is on unlawful material, users and tech firms have raised concerns over compliance pressures and potential overreach. AGENCIES

Delhi Budget puts green

a "triple-engine government". The Budget allocates Rs.19,326 crore for education and Rs.13,034 crore for health, alongside Rs.12,613 crore for transport and Rs.11,572 crore for urban development. A total of Rs.12,746 crore has been set aside for healthcare, with plans to open 750 Ayushman Arogya Mandirs and a new trauma centre at GTB Hospital.

On infrastructure, Gupta announced Rs.5,921 crore for PWD, including Rs.1,392 crore for redevelopment of 7,000 km of roads and Rs.1,352 crore for "dust-free roads". Additionally, Rs.9,000 crore has been allocated to the Delhi Jal Board. In the social sector, Rs.5,110 crore has been earmarked to provide Rs.2,500 monthly assistance to women, while Rs.7,406 crore has been allocated for Women and Child Development. The government also announced "free permits to 1,000 women to run electric autos" and Rs.260 crore for free LPG cylinders during Holi and Diwali.

The transport sector received Rs.8,374 crore, with Gupta reiterating that "the entire fleet of govt buses will be electric by 2029."

'BE PREPARED FOR EVERY EVENTUALITY'

West Asia crisis: PM Modi urges states to work as 'Team India'

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Tuesday announced the constitution of seven empowered groups to deal with the potential long-term impacts of the West Asia war and urged states to work with the Centre in a 'Team India' approach to ward off the crisis.

Observing that the situation is constantly changing in West Asia, he said its adverse effects are likely to persist for an extended time, and called upon citizens to remain prepared for every eventuality.

Flagging 'serious side effects of the war', the Prime Minister recalled the national response to COVID-19, when empowered groups of experts had helped address challenges, and said the seven empowered groups will deal with the consequences of war and evolve strategies on fuel, fertilisers, gas, supply chains and inflation.

In a statement in the Rajya Sabha, he reiterated India's position of dialogue and diplomacy as the only solutions to the restoration of peace in West Asia.

He also said India was in constant touch with all parties, including Iran, Israel and the United States, to stress de-escalation.

While admitting to the unprecedented challenges the war is posing for India in terms of supply of essential goods, including crude, gas and fertilisers, the Prime Minister said going forward "self-reliance was the only option".

Noting that the war has created a serious energy crisis globally, he also warned miscreants against taking advantage of crisis, and has asked state governments to check black marketing



PM Narendra Modi speaks in the Rajya Sabha on Tuesday

HIGHLIGHTS

- » He said its adverse effects are likely to persist for an extended time
- » The PM reiterated India's position of dialogue and diplomacy as the only solutions to the restoration of peace
- » He also said India was in constant touch with all parties to stress de-escalation

and hoarding.

In such a critical situation, it is essential that a united voice of peace and dialogue goes out to the entire world from this Upper House of India's Parliament, Modi said.

He asserted that the government is trying to procure gas and crude oil from all available sources, and efforts on this front will continue in the coming days to ensure that the common people are not affected.

Modi also said necessary preparations have been made for the adequate supply of fertilisers, as he assured farmers that no burden of war falls upon them.

"The government is working with a comprehensive strat-

egy to address every aspect of this crisis -- be it its short-term, medium-term, or long-term implications," he said.

The government, the Prime Minister said, has already constituted an inter-ministerial group, which meets regularly to assess any difficulties in import-export operations and work on devising necessary solutions.

"Much like the empowered groups, comprising experts and officials, that were formed during the COVID-19 pandemic to tackle challenges across various sectors, seven such new empowered groups were constituted just yesterday.

"These groups will be tasked with taking action, guided by both immediate and long-term strategies, on critical issues, such as supply chains, petroleum and diesel, fertilisers, natural gas, and inflation. I am fully confident that through these collective efforts, we will be able to effectively navigate the prevailing circumstances," Modi said.

Noting that the West Asia crisis is of a unique nature, the Prime Minister said its solutions are being devised in a correspondingly distinct manner.

"We must confront every challenge with patience, restraint, and a calm mind," he said.

EARLY ADJOURNMENT OF PARLIAMENT SESSION LIKELY

'Amendment to women quota law faces delay'

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: The government is unlikely to immediately bring a Bill to increase Lok Sabha seats to 816 so that 273 of them could be reserved for women in the ongoing Parliament session, which may be adjourned early but will not be prorogued to keep open the option of reconvening after the upcoming round of assembly elections, according to sources.

The sources indicated that there is very little chance of the government tabling the constitution amendment Bill that will tweak the Nari Shakti Vandan Adhiniyam, commonly known as the women's reservation law, in Parliament in the next few days.

It is learnt that there was no proposal till Tuesday evening to bring the draft Bill before the Union Cabinet, which is scheduled to meet on Wednesday.

"There are requirements

INSIGHT

» It is learnt that there was no proposal till Tuesday evening to bring the draft Bill before the Union Cabinet, which is scheduled to meet on Wednesday

» Union Home minister Amit Shah had on

Monday discussed the matter with some NDA constituents and some non-Congress Opposition floor leaders

» But consultations with the principal Opposition party, Congress, and another major party, TMC, were yet to take place

of seeking further deliberations with all political parties before finalising a schedule for amending the women's reservation law," a source privy to the development said.

Union Home minister Amit Shah had on Monday discussed the matter with some NDA constituents and some non-Congress opposition floor leaders. But consultations with the principal Opposition party, Congress, and another major party, TMC, were yet to take

place.

As there have been talks of curtailment of the ongoing Budget session, sources indicated that there is a possibility of adjournment of the Parliament before the April 2 schedule, but Parliament will not be prorogued so that the same session can be reconvened.

It is learnt that the government is exploring the option of reconvening the session after the five assembly elections next month. The results of the polls

will be declared on May 4.

However, there was no official word from the government on this.

The provision to provide 33 per cent reservation to women in the Lok Sabha and state assemblies was brought by amending the Constitution in 2023, but it will come into effect after the completion of the delimitation exercise.

According to the broad contours available, the number of Lok Sabha seats would be increased from the present 543 to 816, with 273 seats reserved for women. The reservation will also be done in a "vertical basis" with seats allocated for SCs and STs.

The redrawing of the constituencies will be done on the basis of the 2011 census rather than the proposed 2027 census.

A similar exercise will be carried out for state assemblies, where seats will be reserved on a pro-rata basis.

Raipur sanitation workers' death: NHRC seeks report

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: The NHRC on Tuesday said it has issued notices to the district magistrate and senior superintendent of police of Raipur over reports that three sanitation workers died while cleaning a septic tank at a private hospital in this district of Chhattisgarh.

In a statement, the National Human Rights Commission said it has sought a detailed report from the authorities in two weeks.

The human rights panel said it has taken suo motu cognisance of a media report that three sanitation workers died after inhaling toxic gases while cleaning a septic tank at a private hospital in Raipur district on March 17.

Reportedly, the relatives of the victims have alleged that neither the hospital manage-

It has issued notices to the DM and SSP over reports that three sanitation workers died while cleaning a septic tank

ment nor the private contractor provided them safety gear, the NHRC said.

The NHRC has observed that the content of the news report, if true, raises a serious issue of violation of human rights of the victims.

Therefore, the Commission has issued notices to Raipur's district magistrate and senior superintendent of police, seeking a detailed report in two weeks, the statement said.

The report is also expected to include the status of the investigation, it said.

'Brazen attack' on constitutional rights: Rahul on transgender Bill

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: Congress leader Rahul Gandhi on Tuesday said the government's Transgender Persons (Protection of Rights) Amendment Bill, 2026 is a "brazen attack" on the constitutional rights and identity of transgender people, and asserted that his party is strongly opposing the proposed legislation.

The Leader of the Opposition in the Lok Sabha termed the bill "regressive" and alleged that the BJP-led government at the Centre is violating the Constitution and destroying India's rich history of honouring transgender communities in pursuit of its narrow ideas.

"The BJP government's Transgender Persons Amendment Bill is a brazen attack on the Constitutional rights and identity of transgender peo-



ple. This regressive bill strips transgender people of their ability to self identify, violating a Supreme Court judgment; wipes out the diverse cultural identities of communities across India, forces trans people to undergo dehumanising examinations by a medical board, and introduces criminal penalties and surveillance without safeguards," he said.

The BJP government has not consulted the trans community and brought a bill which stigmatises rather than protects them, he claimed.

"The Constitution protects every Indian's right to life, liberty, identity and dignity. This BJP government is violating our Constitution and destroying India's rich history of honouring transgender communities in pursuit of its narrow ideas. The Congress party unequivocally opposes this bill," Gandhi said.

The bill seeking to give a precise definition of the term "transgender" and provide graded punishments that reflect the gravity of the harm inflicted upon such persons was introduced in the Lok Sabha earlier this month.

The bill underlines that a transgender person "shall not include, nor shall ever have been so included, persons with different sexual orientations and self-perceived sexual identities".

'Over 18,000 Jan Aushadhi Kendras opened in last 11 years'

NEW DELHI: Chemicals and Fertilizers Minister JP Nadda on Tuesday highlighted there are 18,646 Jan Aushadhi Kendras across the country that provide generic medicines to people at affordable prices.

Replying to supplementary queries during Question Hour in Rajya Sabha, the minister said that Pradhan Mantri Bhartiya Janaushadhi Pariyojana was launched in 2008 by the UPA government but ruled that only 80 Jan Aushadhi Kendras were opened till 2014.

INDIA'S FIRST CASE OF PASSIVE EUTHANASIA: Harish Rana passes away at AIIMS Delhi

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: Harish Rana, the first person in India to be allowed passive euthanasia, passed away on Tuesday at AIIMS-Delhi after more than 13 years in a coma, sources said.

The 31-year-old, who has been in a coma since 2013, was shifted from his Ghaziabad home to the palliative care unit at Dr BR Ambedkar Institute Rotary Cancer Hospital at the AIIMS on March 14.

Three days before that, the Supreme Court, in a landmark judgment on March 11, allowed passive euthanasia for Harish, who was a BTech student at Panjab University who fell from a fourth-floor balcony in 2013 and suffered severe head injuries.

He had been in a coma since,

with artificial nutrition support and occasional oxygen support.

Passive euthanasia is the intentional act of letting a patient die by withholding or withdrawing life support or the treatment necessary to keep him alive.

Harish's nutritional support was gradually withdrawn after he was admitted to the hospital, the sources said on Tuesday.

Harish's family had said after the apex court judgment that the withdrawal of artificial life support would not bring any personal benefit to the family, but in the larger public interest, the decision could help others facing similar situations.

His father, Ashok Rana, had said passive euthanasia would restore Harish's dignity after years of irreversible suffering.

Pinki Virani, a journalist and activist who filed a peti-

tion for euthanasia to Aruna Shanbaug in 2011, thanked the doctors and nurses at AIIMS for "compassionately applying passive euthanasia", and urged that one should let their family members know "if they would want to exercise this right for themselves".

"May Harish Rana rest in peace. May his parents and his brother find a quiet peace of their own amid what has been a very long loss for them... I continue to be grateful to the Supreme Court for allowing the right to die with dignity in 2011... It's a choice, and if they so choose, they can help the process by making their wishes - pertaining legally to passive euthanasia - known so that their final exit is free from guilt and trauma," Virani said.

DELHI FOURTH MOST POLLUTED CITY IN THE WORLD

India sixth most polluted country; UP's Loni world's most polluted city: Report

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: India is the sixth most-polluted country when it comes to levels of fine particulate matter, a major air pollutant, while UP's Loni is the most polluted city across the globe and Delhi is at the fourth spot, according to the World Air Quality Report, 2025.

The eighth edition of the report published by IQAir, a Swiss air quality technology company, analysed data from monitoring stations across 9,446 cities in 143 countries, regions and territories.

According to the report, Pakistan is the most polluted country, followed by Bangladesh, Tajikistan, Chad and Congo, with India at the sixth spot.

Among the ten most polluted cities across the globe, five are from India—Loni, Byrnihat, Delhi, Ghaziabad and Ula.

"The world's 25 most polluted cities were all located in India, Pakistan and China, with India home to three of the four most polluted. Loni, India, was the most polluted

KEY POINTS

- » The eighth edition of the report published by IQAir analysed data from monitoring stations across 9,446 cities in 143 countries, regions and territories
- » Pakistan is the most polluted country, followed by Bangladesh,



Tajikistan, Chad and Congo, with India at the sixth spot

city, recording an annual average PM2.5 concentration of 112.5 µg/m³—a nearly 23 per cent increase from 2024 and more than 22 times the WHO guideline," the report said.

Comparing this year's report to the previous year, 54 countries experienced a rise in the annual average of PM2.5, 75 saw a drop, two remained unchanged and 12 were newly represented in this year's dataset.

"Only 14 per cent of global cities met the World Health Organization (WHO) annual PM2.5 guideline of 5 µg/m³, down from 17 per cent the pre-

vious year. Only thirteen countries/territories met the WHO annual average PM2.5 guideline—French Polynesia, Puerto Rico, US Virgin Islands, Barbados, New Caledonia, Iceland, Bermuda, Réunion, Andorra, Australia, Grenada, Panama, Estonia," the report said.

Wildfires, intensified by climate change, played a major role in degrading global air quality in 2025. Record biomass emissions from Europe and Canada contributed to approximately 1,380 megatons of carbon.

Canada was the most polluted country in Northern

America for just the second time in the report's eight-year history, as its second-worst wildfire season on record affected air quality across Canada, the US and parts of Europe.

"In the United States, annual average PM2.5 levels increased to 7.3 µg/m³. Smoke from wildfires in both Canada and the US raised averages across parts of the Great Lakes states in the summer and in the Pacific Northwest in the fall. El Paso was the most polluted major city in the United States. Historic dust storms triggered a 46 per cent increase in PM2.5 levels to 11.4 µg/m³ as the city recorded the highest number of major pre-summer dust storms since the 1930s.

"The Southeast Los Angeles region (Cudahy, East Los Angeles, Huntington Park), heavily impacted by wildland-urban interface fires, ranked as the most polluted area in the country. Seattle remained the cleanest major US city for the second consecutive year, with an annual average of 4.5 µg/m³," the report said.

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REVIEW MEETING AMID WEST ASIA CRISIS

Fuel risk & supply disruptions in focus at high-level defence meet

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Amid rising tensions and volatility in West Asia, concerns have emerged over potential disruptions to India's defence exports and supply chains, prompting a high-level meeting here on Tuesday chaired by Defence minister Rajnath Singh.

As per the ministry communication, it was a review meeting over the evolving security situation and for assessing its possible impact on India's defence preparedness.

It was also focused on the possible disruption to the procurement, production, maintenance and serviceability of defence equipment, with particular emphasis on ensuring that existing military platforms remain fully operational.

India's armed forces depend heavily on imported fuel for aircraft, naval ships, tanks, and logistics. Nearly 90 per cent of India's crude oil is imported, much of it through the Gulf region. Around 20 per cent of India's imports pass through the Strait of Hormuz, a key route near Iran. Hence, if conflict escalates, fuel prices will rise, and pressure will mount on the defence budget. Apart from this, military exercises and operations become costlier. Also, strategic reserves may need to be used.

The Defence minister called



Defence Minister Rajnath Singh, CDS General Anil Chauhan, COAS General Upendra Dwivedi, CNS Admiral Dinesh K Tripathi, CAS Air Chief Marshal A P Singh and others during a review meeting on in New Delhi

Highlights

» The meeting was also focused on the possible disruption to the procurement, production, maintenance and serviceability of defence equipment

» India's armed forces

depend heavily on imported fuel for aircraft, naval ships, tanks, and logistics

» The Defence minister called for the formulation of a comprehensive and integrated roadmap for the next decade

for the formulation of a comprehensive and integrated roadmap for the next decade, which should incorporate lessons learned from ongoing global conflicts, address future challenges and opportunities, and prioritise self-reliance in defence production while maintaining a high level of operational readiness across all fronts. At the same time, reportedly, India has already strengthened strategic petroleum reserves and alternative supply plans to handle such

crises.

Indian Navy deployment increases in the Arabian Sea and the Indian Ocean. Whenever West Asia tensions rise, the Indian Navy increases patrols in the Arabian Sea, shipping routes to India must be protected, and oil tankers and cargo ships need escort.

Also, India must ensure the safety of sea lanes, the safety of Indian ships and the safety of Indians in Gulf countries.

The government has also said it is closely monitoring the situation and staying in touch with Indians in the region.

As per the defence ministry officials, stressing the need for constant assessment, the defence minister directed the armed forces and defence establishment to closely study the operational and technological aspects emerging from the current conflict so that India can strengthen its own preparedness.

Strategic balancing between the US and Iran affects defence diplomacy. India has defence ties with the US, but also relations with Iran. Where India and the US share a pact over defence technology, weapons, and intelligence, Iran provides India access to Central Asia and the Chabahar port. Through the Gulf countries, India shares a vast logistics route, and there are around 1 crore Indians in the Gulf countries.

The meeting was attended by the Chief of Defence Staff General Anil Chauhan, the three Service Chiefs - General Upendra Dwivedi (COAS), Admiral Dinesh K Tripathi (CNS) and Air Chief Marshal Amar Preet Singh (CAS), the Defence Secretary Rajesh Kumar Singh, Secretary (Defence Production) Sanjeev Kumar and the Chairman of the Defence Research and Development Organisation (DRDO) Samir V. Kamat.

Apex Court allows pensionary benefits to women SSC officers

SC grants permanent commission as one-time measure

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: The Supreme Court ruled on Tuesday that women Short Service Commission (SSC) officers in the Army, Navy, and Air Force denied permanent commission due to a "systemic disparity" would be entitled to full pensionary benefits.

The top court delivered three separate verdicts challenging the denial of PC (permanent commission) based on policy changes in 2019 and previous Armed Forces Tribunal (AFT) rulings in the Army, Air Force, and Navy.

In the verdict on a plea by Yogendra Kumar Singh related to the Navy, a bench comprising Chief Justice Surya Kant and Justice Joymalya Bagchi granted PC to several groups of SSC Officers, primarily women, as a one-time measure.

The bench set aside the need for yet another selection board, noting that the officers had been subjected to three grueling rounds of litigation over 15 years.

The dispute pertained to how the Navy assessed its officers and the appellants, around 25 officers, said that their annual confidential reports (ACRs) were "casually graded" during the years they were technically ineligible for PC.

"We are of the considered opinion that when officers



work" of discrimination.

The 60-page judgment focused on a group of roughly 73 SSC officers, mostly women, from batches commissioned between 2010 and 2012.

It found that for the first decade of their careers, these women were considered "ineligible" for PC as a matter of policy and, consequently, their ACRs were written by superior officers who assumed the women would only serve a 14-year term.

This led to "casual" or "mid-dling" grades, while their male counterparts were groomed and graded higher for long-term career progression, the court said.

Writing the judgments, the CJI compared the flawed evaluation to "adjusting the lens of a camera to alter the quality of an image captured much earlier", stating, "The damage had been done years before."

The Army had argued that it could only grant 250 PC slots per year to maintain a "youngish" profile of the force.

However, the court rejected the idea that this cap was "sacrosanct" or "immutable", saying that the 250-vacancy ceiling had been breached several times in the past for exigencies such as the Kargil war.

"The invocation of the vacancy cap as a shield against remedial action would be unfair to sustain," it held.

are assessed under the prevailing assumption that they have no future in the service, the appraisal process is inevitably affected from its very inception," the verdict said and termed this a "circularity" where past ineligibility was unfairly transformed into "deemed unsuitability" for career progression.

As a one-time measure, the bench directed grant of PC to in-service Short Service Commission Women Officers (SSCWOs) inducted prior to January 2009 and SSCWOs who joined after January 2009 in branches excluding law, education, and naval architecture.

In its second judgment on a plea by Lt Col Pooja Pal related to the Army, the bench ordered the grant of PC to several batches of women officers and directed the government to provide pensionary benefits to those who were released from service during the legal battle.

It ruled that the Army's evaluation process for women officers was "marred by inequality of opportunity" and rooted in a "systemic frame-

Rape case: Probe against Nashik 'godman' widens

Rs 1,500 cr assets, 100 videos unearthed

MPOST BUREAU

MUMBAI: The Special Investigation Team (SIT) probing cases against self-styled godman and rape accused Ashok Kharat has unearthed assets worth Rs 1,500 crore and 100 objectionable videos, a senior police official said on Tuesday.

With the discovery widening the scope of the investigation, the Nashik Police and Income Tax Department have also been roped in for the probe, the official said.

Kharat, who heads a temple trust at Sinnar in Nashik district and had several political leaders visit him over the years, was arrested on March 18 after a 35-year-old woman accused him of repeated rape over a period of three years.

Two more cases have been registered against him in connection with his alleged sexual exploitation of a seven-month pregnant woman and another woman on the pretext of getting her remarried.

"The SIT has discovered 100 objectionable videos and assets worth around Rs 1,500 crore related to him. While the I-T department is investigating financial irregularities and property holdings of Kharat and people related to him, the cyber police

With the latest discovery, the Nashik Police and I-T dept have also been roped in for the probe

are examining the videos," he said.

A multi-agency investigation is underway, considering the scope and seriousness of the probe, he added.

The expansion aims to manage the complex layers of evidence, including digital forensics and financial trails, he said.

The SIT led by IPS officer Tejaswini Satpute is probing six cases against Kharat and has appealed to the public to come forward with any relevant information related to the criminal cases in Nashik.

The official said that the SIT has assured that the identities of those providing information or reporting a crime committed by the accused will be kept strictly confidential.

The probe team comprises five to 10 officers from the crime branch, including women personnel to handle victims' sensitive statements, the official said.

Resolve party workers' grievances: UP CM to ministers

OUR CORRESPONDENT

LUCKNOW: Uttar Pradesh Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath held a meeting with all ministers following the Cabinet session and issued clear directions to prioritise the concerns of party workers and resolve them with sensitivity.

The meeting comes in the backdrop of feedback received from recent coordination meetings held across six organisational regions of the BJP. Inputs from party workers and functionaries associated with the Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh indicated dissatisfaction over ministers' behaviour and alleged neglect of grievances. Taking note of these concerns, the Chief Minister held a detailed discussion with ministers to address the issue.

He instructed ministers in charge of districts to undertake regular visits and establish direct communication with office bearers and workers at the district, sector and block levels.

More transparency in reservations as Rlys revises chart timing, cracks down on bots

Nearly three crore fake accounts removed from the IRCTC system

SIMONTINI BHATTACHARJEE

NEW DELHI: Now, advanced technological safeguards will crack down on bots, touts and fraudulent software that often deprive genuine passengers of confirmed tickets within seconds of the booking window opening. By deploying bot-detection systems, restricting automated booking tools and introducing Aadhaar-based OTP verification, the Railways moves towards curbing misuse of the Tatkal scheme and making the reservation process more secure, equitable and passenger-friendly.

While announcing a slew of reforms on Tuesday, Rail Minister Aswini Vaishnaw said that this move focuses on passenger convenience, with measures to curb misuse of ticketing systems and improve access for genuine travellers. Ticket black marketing and misuse of the Tatkal system had been a prolonged major concern. Hence, further technological interventions curtailed the ability of agents and touts to book tickets immediately after the Tatkal window opens, along-

KEY POINTS

» Rail Minister Aswini Vaishnaw said that this move focuses on passenger convenience, with measures to curb misuse of ticketing systems and improve access for genuine travellers

» By deploying bot-detection systems, restricting automated booking tools and introducing Aadhaar-based OTP verification, the Railways moves towards curbing misuse of the Tatkal scheme

side the introduction of Aadhaar-based OTP verification. A detailed data analysis led to the identification and removal of nearly 3 crore fake accounts from the IRCTC system, resulting in a significant improvement in ticket availability.

The minister also mentioned, while announcing here in the national capital, that to address this, the earlier cancellation time windows of 48, 12, and 4 hours before departure have been revised to 72, 24, and 8 hours, aligned with the preparation of reservation charts, which now happens 9-18 hours before

departure instead of 4 hours earlier. This will be done at no extra cost to passengers.

As per Vaishnaw, the reservation charts improve passenger convenience by reducing uncertainty, enabling better planning for waitlisted travellers, and supporting passengers from remote locations. Early charting further allows alternative travel arrangements, optimises vacant berth utilisation, and boosts transparency. These changes are aimed at removing incentives for last-minute speculative bookings and ensuring tickets are available to genuine passengers.



» Ticket black marketing and misuse of the Tatkal system had been a prolonged major concern

foreign sources have been traced. Agencies suspect the activity was part of pre-attack reconnaissance, with some accused having travelled to Pulwama to share inputs.

The network recruited economically vulnerable youths with technical skills, while women and minors were used to avoid detection. A key recruiter, Iram alias Mahak, allegedly played a central role.

Officials also uncovered an OTP and SIM card racket enabling foreign operatives to use Indian numbers. The network spanned multiple states and Nepal, with agencies now working to map its full extent and assess implications for national security.



Haryana CM Nayab Singh Saini addresses the media persons after the Cabinet meeting

ing that the impact is being felt globally. To address the situa-

Hry Cabinet clears 18 proposals, relaxes norms for B Pharma posts

MPOST BUREAU

CHANDIGARH: The Haryana Cabinet, in a meeting chaired by Chief Minister Nayab Singh Saini on Tuesday, approved 18 of the 31 agenda items discussed during a nearly six-hour session.

Addressing mediapersons after the meeting, the Chief Minister said the government has relaxed the mandatory six-month training requirement for recruitment to B. Pharma posts,

citing a shortage of eligible candidates and a long-pending demand to fill vacancies.

He also announced the reintroduction of a provision to facilitate loans for employees through the Accountant General (AG), following complaints about difficulties in accessing credit.

On the issue of gas supply disruptions, Saini attributed the problem to ongoing geopolitical tensions in West Asia, stat-

Saini announced the reintroduction of a provision to facilitate loans for employees through the AG

tion, the government is promoting the use of piped natural gas (PNG) as an alternative to LPG. While around five lakh PNG

connections exist in the state, nearly two lakh consumers are not using them, he said.

The Chief Minister added that steps are being taken to curb black marketing of gas and encouraged the adoption of alternatives such as solar stoves and electric cooking appliances. He also said directions have been issued to expedite pipeline expansion by granting deemed permissions in cases facing delays.

MPOST BUREAU

CHANDIGARH: Punjab Chief Minister Bhagwant Singh Mann on Tuesday highlighted a major resurgence in the state's sports sector, citing a sharp rise in participation and investments as part of the government's reform push.

Presenting a sports report card, Mann said participation in sporting activities has increased from 1.5 lakh to nearly 5 lakh players, driven by grassroots initiatives such as "Khedan Watan Punjab Dian." He noted that the sports budget has seen a significant jump from ₹350 crore to ₹1,791 crore, while the number of coaches has risen from 500 to



2,458. The Chief Minister said the state is focusing on infrastructure and talent development, with 3,100 playgrounds and 3,000 gyms being developed, along with the distribution of 17,000 sports kits. Financial support of ₹15 lakh for Olympic preparation and ₹8 lakh for Asian Games athletes has also been introduced.

Mann said Punjab has, for

UP: Kakori martyrs' statues 'demolished' during road work

BISWAJEET BANERJEE

LUCKNOW: Statues of Kakori train action martyrs were allegedly demolished during a road construction project in Shahjahanpur, sparking widespread outrage and political backlash.

The statues of Ram Prasad Bismil, Ashfaqulla Khan and Roshan Singh, installed outside the Municipal Corporation office, were reportedly razed using a bulldozer on Sunday night. Videos circulating on social media showed debris being dumped at a garbage site, fuelling public anger.

Municipal sources said the demolition was carried out by a contractor engaged in a ₹40 lakh road construction and beautification project. Officials claimed the statues were to be replaced and relocated under a smart road plan, but the contractor allegedly acted without informing senior authorities, leading to their damage.

Mayor Archana Verma visited the site, expressed displeasure and sought an explanation from officials.

The incident quickly turned into a political flash-point. Samajwadi Party chief Akhilesh Yadav criticised the move, saying beautification cannot take precedence over respect for martyrs. The party alleged the demolition was deliberate and disrespectful.

Uttar Pradesh Congress chief Ajay Rai also condemned the act, calling it an assault on the legacy of freedom fighters and demanding strict action against those responsible.

A descendant of Ashfaqulla Khan warned of protests, as anger continued to mount over the incident.

NATIONAL STROKE SUMMIT 2026

Centre unveils national action plan to strengthen stroke care

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The Centre on Tuesday unveiled a national action plan to strengthen stroke care at the National Stroke Summit 2026, and emphasised that timely diagnosis and coordinated response systems could significantly reduce mortality and long-term disability from one of India's leading health challenges.

Launching the initiative, Union Health Minister J. P. Nadda said stroke continues to affect individuals and families without warning, underscoring the need for early detection and rapid medical intervention. "Timely diagnosis, quick referral and access to quality treatment can save lives and prevent lifelong disability," he said.

The programme, titled StrokePeRok, included a national framework for prevention and management, as well as the identification of dedicated stroke care centres across the country. Officials said the initiative aimed to integrate emergency response, diagnostics and specialised

TAKEAWAYS

» Launching the initiative, Union Health minister J. P. Nadda said stroke continues to affect individuals and families without warning, underscoring the need for early detection and rapid medical intervention

treatment into a coordinated system.

Highlighting the government's broader healthcare push, Nadda said digital platforms and infrastructure expansion under schemes such as Ayushman Bharat were enabling a more accessible and technology-driven system. However, he stressed that technology alone would not suffice without "coordination, commitment and collective action" among stakeholders.

Minister of State for Health Prataprao Jadhav said the success of the programme would largely depend on implemen-

» 'Timely diagnosis, quick referral and access to quality treatment can save lives and prevent lifelong disability,' he said

» The programme, titled 'Stroke Pe Rok', included a national framework for prevention and management, as well as the identification of dedicated stroke care centres across the country

tation by States. He pointed to efforts to strengthen emergency services, including the wider promotion of the 112 ambulance network, the expansion of critical care units, and the deployment of mobile medical services in rural areas.

A hub-and-spoke model is expected to form the backbone of the strategy, with primary centres identifying and stabilising patients, while specialised hospitals provide advanced care. "States will play a critical role as the success of stroke treatment will depend on how plans are implemented on the ground," Jadhav said.



EDITORIAL
GAS SHOCK
WILL PERSIST

The missile strikes on Qatar’s Ras Laffan complex are not just another episode in an already volatile West Asian conflict. They mark a deeper rupture in the global energy system—one that could keep gas prices elevated for years, not months. For India, which has steadily increased its dependence on liquefied natural gas (LNG) to power industries, fertiliser production and city gas networks, the implications are both immediate and structural. Unlike oil shocks, which markets have learned to absorb and reroute with relative speed, disruptions in LNG infrastructure carry a stubborn permanence. What has been damaged cannot simply be switched back on.

At the heart of the problem is the nature of LNG itself. Natural gas is not traded in its raw form across oceans; it must be cooled to extreme temperatures, converted into liquid, transported in specialised vessels, and then regasified at the destination. Each step depends on capital-intensive, highly calibrated infrastructure that takes years—often decades—to build. Ras Laffan was not just another terminal; it was the backbone of Qatar’s export economy and a critical node in global supply, accounting for a substantial share of LNG traded worldwide. When such a facility is hit, the damage is not just physical—it disrupts a finely balanced system of long-term contracts, shipping routes and supply assurances.

For India, this disruption lands at an awkward moment. The country has been trying to raise the share of gas in its energy mix to around 15 per cent, positioning it as a cleaner transition fuel between coal and renewables. That ambition has already been constrained by price volatility over the past few years. Expensive LNG imports have forced power producers to idle gas-based plants and pushed fertiliser subsidies higher. Now, with Qatar’s capacity impaired and the prospect of prolonged repairs looming, India faces the risk of being priced out once again in a tightening market where cargoes flow to the highest bidder. In such a scenario, long-term contracts offer some insulation—but even they are vulnerable when suppliers invoke force majeure.

The longer-term concern is more structural. LNG markets were already under strain, balancing Europe’s post-Ukraine war demand with Asia’s growing consumption. Qatar had emerged as a stabilising force, expanding capacity and offering relatively predictable supplies. If that anchor weakens, the entire market becomes more volatile. Prices do not just spike—they remain elevated because replacement capacity cannot be created overnight. New liquefaction projects take years to commission, and alternative suppliers such as the United States or Australia operate within their own logistical and regulatory constraints. The result is a prolonged mismatch between demand and supply, which keeps prices firm even after the immediate crisis fades from headlines.

This is where India’s vulnerability becomes evident. Unlike wealthier economies in Europe or East Asia, India is highly sensitive to energy prices. When LNG becomes expensive, the country does not simply absorb the cost—it shifts behaviour. Power producers revert to coal, industrial users cut consumption, and policymakers are forced to recalibrate energy strategies on the fly. This undermines both climate commitments and long-term planning. The current crisis may well reinforce an uncomfortable truth: that gas, often described as a “bridge fuel,” is only as reliable as the geopolitics that surround it.

There is also a strategic lesson here. India’s energy security cannot rest on a narrow set of external suppliers or a single fuel transition pathway. Diversification—of sources, of contracts, and of energy technologies—must move from policy rhetoric to execution. This means expanding domestic gas exploration where feasible, investing in storage and regasification infrastructure, and accelerating renewables not just as a climate imperative but as a hedge against global volatility. It also means rethinking how India participates in global energy markets, including whether it can secure more flexible contracts or equity stakes in upstream assets abroad.

The damage to Qatar’s gas infrastructure is, in that sense, more than an isolated event. It is a reminder that in the energy world, physical shocks often translate into long economic shadows. For India, the challenge is not merely to ride out the current turbulence, but to prepare for a future in which such disruptions are not exceptions but recurring features. If that preparation falls short, the country risks being caught in a cycle where every external shock resets its energy ambitions—and its economic calculations—back to square one.

BHARAT
KI SOCH



ANIL RAJPUT

THE WRITER IS
CHAIRPERSON,
ADVISORY
COUNCIL, ILLNESS
TO WELLNESS
FOUNDATION

His leadership strength lies in correction, not perfection—a reminder that accountability defines leadership more than flawlessness

Mantra of Successful Alliances

Sugriv’s arc in the Ramayana goes beyond exile and restoration, offering a layered reflection on leadership, its obligations, failures and eventual redemption through accountability

“One must always be grateful and steadfast in fulfilling a friend’s purpose; an ungrateful person finds no regard among the noble.”

- Kiskindha Kanda, Sarga 33

In today’s corporate environment, leadership is often viewed through decisive strategy, visible achievement, and performance under pressure. Yet its successful accomplishment lies in the sustained exercise of responsibility, the integrity of commitments, and the ability to foster trust over time. It is equally defined by the alliances leaders forge, and the wisdom with which they sustain them. The Ramayana offers a nuanced view on these dimensions, with Sugriv emerging as a particularly instructive figure. His narrative, shaped by adversity, alliance, lapse, and restoration, is more than a tale of regained power and instead evolves into a reflection on the nature of leadership itself.

Sugriv, the younger brother of Vali (originally Bali), the ruler of Kishkindha, was driven out of the kingdom after a fateful misunderstanding with his brother. While accompanying Vali, who was pursuing a demon, he stood guard outside the cave where Vali was fighting the demon. From inside, he heard terrifying sounds and saw blood flow out. Assuming that Vali, renowned as a fearless warrior, had slayed the demon, he returned to Kishkindha, where he was reluctantly made king. However, when Vali returned alive, enraged at what he perceived as betrayal, he exiled Sugriv and even took his wife, Ruma. Sugriva’s fortunes changed when he encountered Ram during his banishment, who was then searching for Sita. Facilitated by Hanuman, they forged an alliance whereby Sugriv agreed to assist in finding Sita, while Ram would help him regain the kingdom of Kishkindha. It was as much an alliance of mutual benefit as it was of mutual convenience.

Sugriv’s alliance with Ram not only alters the course of the epic but also demonstrates that leadership cannot remain confined to convenience and benefit. Once Sugriv was restored to power through Ram’s intervention, the hardship of exile was replaced by the comforts of regained authority. The sense of urgency that once defined his reinstatement begins to diminish. Surrounded by security, power, and comfort, Sugriv allows complacency to overshadow commitment and obligation to yield to circumstance. It is here that the transition from convenience to conviction becomes critical. Alliances that begin as convenience must be sustained through conviction if they are to



Sugriv’s story is not about power regained, but about responsibility reclaimed—and that is where true leadership resides

succeed. The responsibility to honour pledges made, even when the original urgency has receded, defines the integrity of leadership. Sugriv’s momentary lapse, when he delays his promise to assist Ram, reflects the risks inherent when convenience is not transformed into fulfillment of obligations. The episode serves as a reminder that alliances meet their objectives only when they honour commitments and not abandon them once immediate gains are achieved.

This lapse also reveals a deeper dimension of leadership, the movement from personalities to principles. Sugriv’s delay is not born of ill intent, but of human fallibility. Surrounded by regained comfort and authority, he allows his situation to outweigh obligation. In doing so, leadership becomes momentarily anchored in personal well-being rather than in principled conduct. It is Lakshman’s intervention that restores this balance. Lakshman confronts Sugriv with firm resolve, reminding him of the promise made to Ram and the consequences of neglecting it. His words are neither conciliatory nor hostile, but measured, direct, and anchored in dharma, compelling Sugriv to realise his shortcomings. His firm reminder that commitments are not optional but binding reignites Sugriv’s sense of responsibility.

The significance of this moment lies not merely in course correction, but in the manner of response. Sugriv does not defend his inaction or seek justification. He listens, reflects, and acts. The ability to accept counsel, especially when it challenges one’s comfort, is central to principled leadership. He immediately mobilises his forces, issues clear directions, and recommitments to the search for

Sita without delay. It is often in moments of stability, rather than crisis, that leaders tend to disregard commitments. Sugriv’s course correction illustrates that leadership grounded in principles is sustained not by infallibility, but by the willingness to realign when deviation occurs.

As Sugriv recommitments to his promise, the alliance enters its most meaningful phase. What began as a mutually beneficial arrangement must now demonstrate tangible outcomes. He translates this intent by mobilising the vast Vanara forces and dispatching search parties in all directions with clear mandates and timelines. By entrusting capable leaders like Hanuman with the southern operation, he ensures that the alliance delivers decisive results in the search for Sita. This marks the transition from seat sharing to value creation. Alliances that remain symbolic tend to fail to deliver lasting impact. Their true measure lies in the value they generate. Sugriv’s leadership during the search for Sita reflects this shift. He organises the vanara forces with meticulous clarity, assigns clear responsibilities, and ensures effective coordination across regions. By entrusting key responsibilities to capable individuals such as Hanuman, Angada, and Jambavan, he aligns individual strengths with organisational priorities. The alliance thus begins to produce outcomes that neither side could have achieved independently. Leadership here becomes the orchestration of collective effort.

His conduct during the war in Lanka further reinforces this principle. Though a king, Sugriv does not intend to dominate the progress of the alliance. He contributes as a committed partner within a larger framework led by Ram. Yet, he

plays his part. He leads from the front in battle, engages directly with key adversaries, supports strategic offensives, and ensures that the vanara forces remain coordinated and responsive to the alliance’s requirements. The emphasis shifts from position to purpose. Leadership, in such contexts, is not defined by control, but by contribution. The alliance ultimately culminates in victory, not because power was shared, but because value was created through aligned effort.

This phase also underscores a broader strategic truth. Alliances, when structured effectively, expand capability, reduce vulnerability, and convert competition into complementarity. They enable leaders to access strengths beyond their immediate domain while distributing risk across a wider base of support. In doing so, they create resilience that cannot be achieved in isolation. Sugriv’s alignment with Ram is not merely an instance of cooperation but a demonstration of how complementary strengths, when brought together with clarity of purpose, can achieve outcomes far greater than individual effort. Leadership, therefore, must evaluate alliances not by their visibility but by the value they generate and the resilience they build within the system.

Across these phases, Sugriv’s evolution reflects a broader truth about leadership. Alliances provide strength, but their effectiveness depends on the principles that sustain them and the outcomes they deliver. Convenience may initiate alignment, but conviction must sustain it. Personalities may influence decisions, but principles must guide them. Participation may signal partnership, but value creation defines its success.

The Ramayana continues to hold relevance today not merely as a narrative of epic proportions but as a repository of such insights into human conduct and institutional behaviour. Among the layered aspects of leadership, the role of effective alliances, sustained by wisdom and the discipline to act with integrity, is demonstrated through the brief yet impactful narrative of Sugriv. His character reminds us that leadership is not a static attribute but an evolving responsibility. It demands resilience in adversity, humility in success, and integrity in action. In a corporate world often driven by immediate outcomes, his journey calls for disciplined reflection on the obligations that follow achievement. Leadership, as his life reveals, is ultimately measured not by the power one attains but by the commitments one upholds and the value one creates through them.

Views expressed are personal

SUPPLY
CHAINS



JAIDEEP VAIDEESWAR

THE WRITER
IS A FORMER
CONSULTANT TO
MYGOV INDIA

India’s structural constraints in tobacco, including FDI limits and a lack of innovation frameworks, risk weakening export competitiveness and long-term global demand

India’s Tobacco Blind Spot?

Global tobacco production is reorganising around innovation, regulation and proximity, raising difficult questions about India’s long-term export competitiveness

Structural shift is quietly reshaping the global tobacco value chain — and it carries significant implications for India’s tobacco export competitiveness.

Across markets, tobacco manufacturers are increasingly locating production closer to end-consumer demand centres. This shift is not merely logistical; it reflects a broader realignment driven by regulatory environments, innovation policy, and the rapid growth of smoke-free and next-generation nicotine products.

Manufacturing today is gravitating toward geographies that permit investment in tobacco product facilities, allow the commercialisation of innovative formats such as heated tobacco, provide integrated supply ecosystems, and demonstrate growing consumer demand for reduced-risk alternatives. As a result, new manufacturing hubs are expanding across parts of Eastern Europe, Latin America, Africa and Southeast Asia.

This evolution has important implications for leaf procurement.

Tobacco leaf is no longer traded as a standalone commodity in isolation. Increasingly, it is sourced as part of integrated manufacturing systems. When companies establish production clusters in a region, procurement strategies often align accordingly. Manufacturers seek to reduce logistics costs, improve supply predictability, meet sustainability and traceability requirements, and optimise working capital by sourcing leaf closer to production facilities.

Origins such as Brazil, Zimbabwe and Mozambique have benefited from this integration model, where contract farming, processing infrastructure and manufacturing ecosystems are more tightly aligned. As manufacturing investments grow in or near these regions, leaf sourcing tends to follow.

For India — one of the world’s largest producers and exporters of flue-



The global tobacco business is no longer being shaped only by cultivation and trade

cured Virginia (FCV) tobacco — this trend presents a strategic challenge.

India remains heavily concentrated in raw leaf cultivation and export. At the same time, foreign direct investment (FDI) in tobacco product manufacturing is prohibited, and innovative nicotine delivery formats are not permitted. This creates a structural imbalance in the value chain: India supplies raw material, while higher-value downstream processing, manufacturing and technology development take place elsewhere.

As global demand gradually shifts toward smoke-free and reduced-risk products, manufacturing capital is flowing to markets that enable regulated innovation. Procurement decisions are increasingly tied to those manufacturing footprints. Over time, this could intensify price competition for Indian leaf, increase substitution risk within international blends, and constrain participation in long-term strategic sourcing contracts.

In a world where manufacturing location increasingly influences procurement decisions, countries that

enable calibrated, regulated innovation are attracting not only capital but also integrated sourcing arrangements and advanced processing infrastructure.

For India, the question is not about abandoning its position as a leading leaf exporter, but about strengthening it. Opening a calibrated pathway for FDI in tobacco manufacturing and enabling a regulated framework for next-generation products could anchor portions of the global value chain domestically. This would expand value addition, enhance export resilience, and secure sustained demand for Indian tobacco leaf.

Absent such alignment, India risks remaining confined to the lowest-value segment of a value chain that is progressively reorganising around innovation-driven demand centres.

The global shift is already underway. The strategic response will determine whether India remains a price-taker — or becomes a value creator — in the next phase of the tobacco economy.

Views expressed are personal



WHO SAID
WHAT



Rajdeep Sardesai
@sardesairajdeep

No person who professes a religion other than Hinduism, Sikhism or Buddhism shall be a member of Scheduled caste. Conversion to any other religion results in loss of Scheduled caste status : Supreme Court. Basically, Dalit Christians can’t take advantage of SC protection. Qs is: does religion change end caste discrimination? Courts may need a reality check!



Mahua Moitra
@MahuaMoitra

All of us have cases pending in SC. Nobody usually dares criticise anything. But surely putting Sonam Wangchuk in illegal detention for 6 months has to have some consequence for govt? What next- robbers returning loot, rapists saying sorry & going scot free?





सेन्ट्रल बैंक ऑफ इंडिया
Central Bank of India

DEMAND NOTICE 13(2)
OF SECURITISATION ACT 2002

1911 से आपके लिए "केन्द्रित" "CENTRAL" TO YOU SINCE 1911

BRANCH OFFICE: G.T. ROAD, DADRI, GAUTAM BUDDHA NAGAR-203207

Demand Notice Under Section 13(2) of the Securitization and Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest (SARFAESI) Act, 2002 to the Borrower/s and Guarantor/s.

This Demand Notice is hereby given under section 13(2) of the Securitisation and Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act, 2002 (54 of 2002) read with rule 3 of the Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules, 2002 hereinafter calling upon the under mentioned Borrowers / Guarantors to repay, the Amounts outstanding for the Credit Facilities granted to them / on their Guarantee, within 60 days from the date of this Notice. If you fail to repay to the Bank the below mentioned amount with further interest and incidental expenses, costs etc. in terms of this notice u/s 13(2) of the Act, the Bank will exercise all or any of the rights detailed under Sub-Section (4) of Section 13 and under other applicable provisions of the said Act. You are also put on notice that in terms of sub-section 4 of Section 13 you shall not transfer by sale, lease or otherwise the said secured assets detailed below of this notice without obtaining written consent of the Bank. The details of the account and Secured Assets along with Amount Outstanding is given below:-

SCHEDULE OF IMMOVABLE PROPERTY & OTHER DETAILS		
Name of Borrower and Guarantor	Description of the Secured Asset	Date & Amount of 13(2) Notice
BORROWER: SH. PRINCE S/O SH. RANVEER (PARTNER M/S JAGDAMBE TILES AND STONE TRADING CO) Village Ganauli, Jafarabad Ghaziabad, U.P.-201102 GUARANTOR: SH. SATYAVIR S/O SH. KISHANLAL Village Ghanghola, Maicha Gautam Buddha Nagar, UP-201310	IMMOVABLE ASSET: Complete detailed description of Immovable property Land & Building and details of title deed with its boundaries Property No. B-2/152, Plot No 152, Block B-2, Yamuna Vihar, New Delhi 110053. Area measuring 70.00Sqm in the name of Sh. Satyavir S/o Sh. Kishanlal Boundaries: East: Plot No 153 West: Plot No 151 North: Road South: Service Lane	Date of 13(2) Notice: 28/02/2026 NPA : 27/02/2026 Rs.70,77,888.00 (Rupees Seventy Lakh Seventy Seven Thousand Eight Hundred Eighty Eight Only) with further interest at the applicable rate/s of interest mentioned in the Schedule A from the date of notice 28/02/2026 till the date of full and final payment along with incidental expenses, charges and costs recoverable from you as per terms of contract and/or as per law, within sixty days from the date of this notice.

YOUR ATTENTION IS DRAWN TO THE PROVISIONS OF SECTION 13(8) OF THE SARFAESI ACT, 2002 IN RESPECT OF TIME AVAILABLE TO YOU TO REDEEM THE SECURED ASSETS.

DATE: 24.03.2026
PLACE: NEW DELHI

Sd/- Authorised Officer,
Central Bank of India

NORTHERN RAILWAY
OPEN TENDER NOTICE

NO: 128-W/Sr.DEN-C/NIT-20-25-26-WC
The Sr. Divisional Engineer/C, Northern Railway, DRM Office, Delhi Division, State Entry Road, New Delhi-110055, for and on behalf of the President of India invites open electronic-tenders for under noted works:-

S. No.	Name of work	Approximate Cost of work	Earnest Money to be deposited	Completion Period	Date of Opening
1.	Supply, Installation, Commissioning & Operation (For 5 Years) of Track Based Rail Gauge Face Lubricator 238 Nos, (Electronic Type for 1Km) Complete System as per RDSO's Technical Specification over Delhi division under DEN/Track.	Rs. 297957790.70	Rs. 1639800/-	60 Months	16.04.2026

The e-tender is to be submitted through railway website 'https://www.ireps.gov.in'. The tenders can be submitted on website up to 15:00 hrs. on 16.04.2026 and shall be opened there after.

SERVING CUSTOMERS WITH A SMILE
985/26

कार्यालय जिला परिषद्, कोडरमा
निविदा से संबंधित शुद्धि पत्र

अति अल्पकालीन निविदा आमंत्रण सूचना संख्या-04 / 2025-26 (Third Call) में इस कार्यालय के पत्रांक 157 / जि०प० दिनांक 18.03.2026 PR No 375705 दिनांक 20.03.2026 द्वारा आंशिक संशोधन किया गया था, जिसमें अपरिहार्य कारणवश पुनः निम्नवत् आंशिक संशोधन किया जाता है।

क्र०	गुप संख्या	योजना का नाम	वेबसाइट में निविदा प्रकाशन की तिथि	पूर्व में प्रकाशित तिथि	ई-निविदा प्राप्ति की तिथि एवं समय	निविदा खोलने की तिथि एवं समय	वेबसाइट में निविदा प्रकाशन की तिथि	ई-निविदा प्राप्ति की तिथि एवं समय	निविदा खोलने की तिथि एवं समय
1	01	Construction of Zila Parishad Koderma Office Building	20.03.2026	20.03.2026 से 28.03.2026 अपराह्न 05:00 बजे तक	30.03.2026 पूर्वाह्न 11:00 बजे	24.03.2026	24.03.2026	01.04.2026 अपराह्न 05:00 बजे तक	02.04.2026 पूर्वाह्न 11:00 बजे

निविदा की अन्य शर्तें यथावत रहेंगी।
PR 375904 Panchayati Raj(25-26).D

जिला अभियंता,
जिला परिषद्, कोडरमा



M.P. ROAD DEVELOPMENT CORPORATION LIMITED
(Govt. of M.P. Undertaking)
45-A, Arera Hills, Bhopal – 462 011, Madhya Pradesh, CIN : U45203MP2004SGC016758
Phone : 0755-2527290, 2765205, (EPBX) Fax : 0755-2572643, Website : www.mprdc.gov.in
NIT No.703/MPRDC/Procu/2026

NOTICE INVITING TENDERS

Madhya Pradesh Road Development Corporation Limited (MPRDC) Bhopal invites online tenders for the following works.

S. No.	Name of Work	PAC Value (in INR Lacs)	Bid Security (EMD) (in INR Lacs)	Cost of Tender Document including GST (in Rs.)	Period of Completion Services
1.	Maintenance of Goharganj to Bhopal section of NH-12 from existing Km 255/300 to km 301/200 and Obedulagani bypass from existing km 278/450 of NH-12 to existing km 3/600 of NH-69 in the state of Madhya Pradesh to four lanes with paved shoulder on EPC mode under NHDP-III on the risk and cost of the EPC contractor.	1350.20	13.50	35,400/-	03 months
2.	Construction of RCC Drain & Box Cell Culvert (3M x 3M) from Mandi to Shankar Nagar in Patan Town on Jabalpur-Patan-Shahpura Road (SH-21A)	114.40	1.14	14750/-	06 Months
3.	Refilling and Replacement of accessories including OPC drum for Printers for MPRDC Head Office, Bhopal	6.92	0.14	2,360/-	12 Months

The dates for purchase, submission, etc. are mentioned in the key dates. Tender forms can be purchased online only upto 15:30 hrs. on 28.04.2026 from website **www.mptenders.gov.in**. The bidders have to submit the Technical bid as well as Financial Bid online only. The Addendum/Corrigendum (if any) shall only be published on the website of **www.mptenders.gov.in** only. If holiday is declared by Govt. of M.P. on the date of opening, the same will automatically be shifted to subsequent working days. MPRDC reserves the right to accept/reject any/all tenders without assigning any reason thereof. M.P. Madhyam/125023/2026
MANAGING DIRECTOR



सेन्ट्रल बैंक ऑफ इंडिया
Central Bank of India

DEMAND NOTICE 13(2)
OF SECURITISATION ACT 2002

1911 से आपके लिए "केन्द्रित" "CENTRAL" TO YOU SINCE 1911

BRANCH OFFICE: G.T. ROAD, DADRI, GAUTAM BUDDHA NAGAR-203207

Demand Notice Under Section 13(2) of the Securitization and Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest (SARFAESI) Act, 2002 to the Borrower/s and Guarantor/s.

This Demand Notice is hereby given under section 13(2) of the Securitisation and Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act, 2002 (54 of 2002) read with rule 3 of the Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules, 2002 hereinafter calling upon the under mentioned Borrowers / Guarantors to repay, the Amounts outstanding for the Credit Facilities granted to them / on their Guarantee, within 60 days from the date of this Notice. If you fail to repay to the Bank the below mentioned amount with further interest and incidental expenses, costs etc. in terms of this notice u/s 13(2) of the Act, the Bank will exercise all or any of the rights detailed under Sub-Section (4) of Section 13 and under other applicable provisions of the said Act. You are also put on notice that in terms of sub-section 4 of Section 13 you shall not transfer by sale, lease or otherwise the said secured assets detailed below of this notice without obtaining written consent of the Bank. The details of the account and Secured Assets along with Amount Outstanding is given below:-

SCHEDULE OF IMMOVABLE PROPERTY & OTHER DETAILS		
Name of Borrower and Guarantor	Description of the Secured Asset	Date & Amount of 13(2) Notice
BORROWER: SMT MANJU W/O.SH. SHAUKIN (PARTNER M/S JAGDAMBE TILES AND STONE TRADING CO) Village Ghanghola, Ajayabpur Gautam Buddha Nagar, U.P.-201310.	IMMOVABLE ASSET: Complete detailed description of Immovable property Land & Building and details of title deed with its boundaries Property No.B-2/152, Plot No.152, Block B-2, Yamuna Vihar, New Delhi -110053. Area measuring 70.00 Sqm in the name of Sh. Satyavir S/o Sh. Kishanlal Boundaries: East: Plot No 153 West: Plot No 151 North: Road South: Service Lane	Date of 13(2) Notice: 28/02/2026 NPA : 27/02/2026 Rs.70,77,888.00 (Rupees Seventy Lakh Seventy Seven Thousand Eight Hundred Eighty Eight Only) with further interest at the applicable rate/s of interest mentioned in the Schedule A from the date of notice 28/02/2026 till the date of full and final payment along with incidental expenses, charges and costs recoverable from you as per terms of contract and/or as per law, within sixty days from the date of this notice.

YOUR ATTENTION IS DRAWN TO THE PROVISIONS OF SECTION 13(8) OF THE SARFAESI ACT, 2002 IN RESPECT OF TIME AVAILABLE TO YOU TO REDEEM THE SECURED ASSETS.

DATE: 24.03.2026
PLACE: NEW DELHI

Sd/- Authorised Officer,
Central Bank of India

PRAISES HEGSETH FOR HIS QUICK RESPONSE ON THE ISSUE

‘Let’s do it’: Trump pins Iran strike decision on Pete in explosive claim

WASHINGTON: US President Donald Trump has said that Secretary of War Pete Hegseth was the “first one” to suggest a possible attack on Iran when he discussed what he described as the “problem in the Middle East” with his close group of advisers.

Speaking at the Memphis Safe Task Force Roundtable in Tennessee on Monday, Trump recounted that he had convened multiple senior officials, including Hegseth and Chairman of the Joint Chiefs of Staff Air Force Gen Dan Caine, to assess the situation in Iran before arriving at a decision. He described the discussions as wide-ranging and aimed at evaluating potential responses to what he characterized as a growing regional threat.

“I called Pete, I called General Caine. I called a lot of our great people... And I said, ‘Let’s talk. We got a problem in the Middle East. We have a country, known as Iran, that for 47 years has been just a purveyor of terror, and they’re very close to having a nuclear weapon. We can keep going



President Donald Trump with Defense Secretary Pete Hegseth

In Short

» Trump said he called all his aides, including Hegseth and Chairman of the Joint Chiefs Air Force Gen Dan Caine, to discuss the situation in Iran before making the decision

» Trump praised Hegseth for his quick response on the issue. “Pete, I think you were the first one to speak up and you said let’s do it,” Trump asserted

and get that 50,000 up to 55 and 60, there’s no end, or we can take a stop and make a little journey into the Middle East and eliminate a big problem,” Trump said during the event.

The US president, who has faced criticism domestically over his administration’s posture toward Iran, also praised Hegseth’s responsiveness during the consultation process. According to Trump, Hegs-

eth was among the first to react decisively when the topic of possible military action was raised.

“Pete, I think you were the first one to speak up and you said let’s do it because you can’t let them have a nuclear weapon,” he said, attributing a key moment of agreement to Hegseth’s position.

Trump further emphasized that the decision-making pro-

cess involved input from multiple senior figures across the US defense and military establishment, suggesting that the final course of action followed internal discussions rather than a unilateral directive.

Earlier, Trump also addressed developments related to Iran on social media, stating that he had extended the deadline for Tehran to reopen the Strait of Hormuz,

a strategically significant maritime passage connecting the Persian Gulf with the Gulf of Oman. He added that the United States would temporarily hold off on potential strikes against Iranian energy infrastructure for a period of five days. The US president did not provide additional operational details but indicated that diplomatic channels may still be active.

AGENCIES

At least 66 killed in military plane crash in Colombia

Goes down shortly after taking off with 128 on board

BOGOTA: A military transport plane with 128 people on board, mostly soldiers, crashed shortly after taking off Monday in Puerto Leguizamo, Colombia, killing at least 66 people and leaving dozens injured, the head of Colombia’s armed forces said.

General Hugo Alejandro Lopez Barreto said that four military personnel were still missing.

“Sadly, as a consequence of this tragic accident, 66 of our military elements died,” he said.

“At the moment, we have no information, or indications, that it was an attack by an illegal armed group,” Barreto added.

In a video posted on social media, Deputy Mayor Carlos Claros said that the bodies of the victims were taken to the small town’s morgue, and that the only two clinics in town treated the injured before they were flown to larger cities.

Puerto Leguizamo is located in Putumayo, an Amazonian province that borders Ecuador and Peru. “I want to thank the people of Puerto Leguizamo who came out to help the victims of this accident,” Claros told Colombian television station RCN.

Defence Minister Pedro Sanchez said on X that the plane that crashed Monday was transporting troops to another



An injured soldier arrives at a military base for treatment in Bogota

128 people on board, including 115 were from the Army, 11 crew members

city in Putumayo.

Images shared online by Colombian media outlets showed a black cloud of smoke rising from a field where the plane crashed and a truck with soldiers rushing to the site.

The airplane had 128 people on board, including 115 were from the Army, 11 crew members and 2 from the National Police. Barreto said 57 people were evacuated.

Media outlets shared videos of soldiers being rushed from the site on motorcycles driven by local residents, while

another group of residents tried to put out the fire that the plane crash had created in a field surrounded by dense foliage.

Carlos Fernando Silva, the commander of Colombia’s air force, said details of the crash were not yet known, “except that the plane had a problem and went down about 2 km from the airport.”

The air force commander added that two planes, with 74 beds, were sent to the area to fly the injured back to hospitals in the capital, Bogota, and elsewhere.

Petro seized on the accident to promote what he called his longtime campaign to modernize planes and other equipment used by his country’s military, saying those efforts have been blocked by “bureaucratic difficulties” and suggesting that some officials should be held accountable.

AGENCIES



NORTH CENTRAL RAILWAY

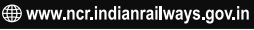
E-Procurement Tender Notice No.: 26/10
Date: 24.03.2026

E-PROCUREMENT TENDER NOTICE

On behalf of the President of India, The Principal Chief Materials Manager, North Central Railway, Prayagraj, (An ISO 9001:2015 certified unit) invites the following E-Procurement Tenders.

S. N.	Tender No.	Short Description	Qty.	Tender Opening Date
1	30252393	SET OF 75 TON DRAFT GEAR ASSEMBLY	74 Set	06.04.2026
2	30261666	WEARING PIECE FOR SIDE BEARER	2252 Nos.	21.04.2026
3	38262762	Snubber Spring	4699 NOS	16.04.2026
4	38262759	Inner Spring	5250 NOS	20.04.2026
5	80254109A	LUBRICATING MOBIL OIL Part No: 15W40 API-CF-4	51030 Ltrs	22-APR-26
6	80261441	*TRANSFORMER OIL FOR THREE PHASE LOCOMOTIVES	48,849 Ltrs	28-APR-26
7	80254101E	HYD OIL Part No: HLP-68N	246288 Ltrs	13-APR-26

Note: The complete information of above tenders can be seen and downloaded from IREPS website i.e. **https://www.ireps.gov.in**. For any change/corrigendum in tender, please visit this website regularly. No separate corrigendum/change will be published in news paper.
659/26 (ADM)





NORTH CENTRAL RAILWAY

E-Tender Notice
Date: 23.03.2026

Senior Divisional Signal & Telecommunication Engineer/Coordination/North Central Railway/Prayagraj, for and on behalf of the President of India, invites **E-TENDER** on prescribed form for the following works up to 12:00 hrs. on 17.04.2026. The details of the Tender is as under:-

E-Tender No.:	PRYJ-Sig-049-2025-26	Approx Cost of work (₹)	1,11,10,407/-
Name of work :	Telecom work in connection with provision of FOB with Ramp at Chunar [CAR], Manauri [MRE] Bharwari [BRE] and Sirathu [SRO] stations.		
Bid Security (₹) :	2,22,200/-	Cost of Tender form (₹) :	0/-
Completion Period :	12 months		
Date of Closing of tender :	17.04.2026		
Availability of tender form :	Tender forms are available on www.ireps.gov.in 21 days prior to date of opening of the tender.		
Time date & place of opening of tender :	Tender will be opened through E-tender at office of Divisional Railway Manager, Prayagraj on or after pre determined date at 12:30 hours. In case tender opening date happens to be holiday, Tenders will be opened on the next working day.		
			649/26 (D)
  			

CUTS MOLDOVAN POWER LINE

Russia fires nearly 400 drones at Kyiv



Rescue workers try to put out a fire in Ukraine's Zaporizhzhia

TEL AVIV/NEW DELHI: Sixteen people have been killed and over 4,500 injured in Israel since the conflict with Iran began late last month, according to Israel’s emergency medical service.

The conflict in West Asia began on February 28, when joint US-Israeli strikes targeted Iranian military and leadership sites.

Chaim Rafalowski, Disaster Management Coordinator at Israel’s national emergency medical service, Magen David Adom (MDA), said on Monday that 16 fatalities have been reported, while 4,564 people have received hospital treatment since late February.

Speaking to PTI videos

from Tel Aviv, Rafalowski said the Ministry of Health confirmed the figures, with injuries stemming from direct missile impacts, shrapnel from intercepted projectiles, or accidents during shelter-seeking.

A “recent fatality occurred yesterday on the border with Lebanon, where a farmer was killed in artillery shelling by Hezbollah,” Rafalowski said.

Hezbollah has intensified rocket and artillery fire into northern Israel amid the broader escalation.

The MDA officer highlighted that despite weeks of sustained alerts, sirens, and sheltering, stress-related medical cases have remained comparatively low.

AGENCIES

Israel says 16 killed, over 4K hurt in war

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AGENCIES

SAYS 'READY AND HONOURED' TO FACILITATE TALKS

PM Sharif pitches Pakistan as mediator in US and Iran peace push

ISLAMABAD: Pakistan Prime Minister Shehbaz Sharif on Tuesday said that Islamabad was "ready and honoured" to facilitate "meaningful and conclusive talks" between the US and Iran to end the ongoing conflict.

The announcement came following media reports about backdoor efforts by Pakistan along with Egypt and Turkiye to broker peace in West Asia.

"Pakistan welcomes and fully supports ongoing efforts to pursue dialogue to end the war in the Middle East, in the interest of peace and stability in the region and beyond," Sharif said in a post on X.

"Subject to concurrence by the US and Iran, Pakistan stands ready and honoured to be the host to facilitate meaningful and conclusive talks for a comprehensive settlement of the ongoing conflict," he added.

Hours later, US President Donald Trump shared Sharif's post on his Truth Social platform. Earlier, the Foreign Office (FO) responding to media queries urged to avoid speculation and await official



Pakistan maintains close ties with both Iran and the Trump administration

FILE

In Short

» According to report, Pakistan's Chief of Defence Forces Field Marshal Asim Munir spoke to US President Donald Trump on Sunday seeking a mediation role between the US and Iran

» Various international media outlets reported about Islamabad being the possible venue of talks as the war entered its fourth week

announcements about the venue for talks between the US and Iranian representatives.

"Pakistan, consistent with its longstanding policy, remains committed to the resolution of the ongoing conflict in the Middle East and Persian Gulf through diplomatic means and engagements," FO spokesperson Tahir Andrabi said.

"Diplomacy and negotia-

tions often require that certain matters be advanced with discretion. The media is therefore encouraged to refrain from speculation and to await official announcements regarding decisions and outcomes," he said.

Various international media outlets reported about Islamabad being the possible venue of talks as the war entered its fourth week.

According to the British daily Financial Times, Pakistan's Chief of Defence Forces Field Marshal Asim Munir spoke to US President Donald Trump on Sunday seeking a mediation role between the US and Iran.

On Monday, Trump had announced on his social media platform that the US would hold off on threatened strikes against Iranian power plants

for five days, saying Washington had held "very good and productive conversations with Tehran" over the previous couple of days. Trump refused to name the Iranian leader the US is in talks with, asserting that the interlocutor was a "top person" who is "most respected" in that country. CNN reported that the US sent Iran a list of 15 demands outlining its expectations through Pakistan. AGENCIES

Asia boosts coal use as Iran war squeezes global LNG supplies

Coal demand rises as global gas supplies tighten

BANGKOK: Asian countries are turning to coal as the Iran war disrupts oil and gas shipments.

The continent is exposed because it relies on imported fuel, much of it passing through the Strait of Hormuz — a chokepoint for about a fifth of global oil and natural gas trade.

LNG is natural gas cooled to liquid form for easy storage and transport. It has been promoted as a bridge fuel in the shift from oil and coal to cleaner energy sources. The US has sought to expand exports of LNG across Asia. It burns cleaner than coal, but still emits climate change -causing gases, especially methane.

The war has countries shifting back to coal to cover LNG shortfalls. India is burning more coal to meet higher summer demand. South Korea has lifted caps on electricity from coal. Indonesia is prioritising using its domestic supply. Thailand, the Philippines and Vietnam are boosting coal-fired power. Burning more coal risks worsening smog in major cities, slowing the transition to renewable energy and increasing the region's planet-



A worker works at coal mine in Jharkhand's Dhanbad

AP

Coal is a short-term fix, experts say

warming emissions.

Coal is a short-term fix, experts say, while renewables are the long-term solution. Continued reliance on coal exposes Asia to future shocks, said Julia Skorupska of the global coalition Powering Past Coal Alliance.

"This kind of crisis is a real sort of warning," she said.

Coal is integral to Asia's emergency energy plans. Its wide availability in Asia makes

it the default backup when renewables or gas fall short, said Sandeep Pai, an energy expert at Duke University.

China, the top coal consumer and producer, has built record coal power generating capacity since 2021 to improve its energy security. Its national policy calls for continued use of coal, even as its vast clean energy capacity offers some relief.

India, the second-largest coal consumer and producer, is bracing for a scorching summer and will rely more on coal to meet peak demand of 270 gigawatts — nearly twice the electricity Spain can produce. AGENCIES

Kim vows to 'irreversibly' cement North Korea's nuclear status

SEOUL: North Korean leader Kim Jong Un has pledged to irreversibly cement his country's status as a nuclear power while maintaining a hard-line stance toward South Korea, which he called the "most hostile" state, state media said Tuesday.

In a speech Monday to Pyongyang's rubber-stamp parliament, Kim accused the United States of global "state terrorism and aggression," in an apparent reference to the war in the Middle East, and said the

Kim accused United States of global "state terrorism and aggression"

North will play a more forceful role in a united front against Washington amid rising anti-American sentiment.

But Kim didn't call out US President Donald Trump by name and said whether his adversaries "choose confrontation or peaceful coexistence is up to them, and we are prepared to respond to any choice."

His comments largely aligned with his statements at last month's ruling Workers' Party Congress, where he vilified Seoul but left open the door for dialogue with the Trump administration, urging Washington to drop its demands for the North's nuclear disarmament as a precondition for talks. AGENCIES

Philippines hits energy emergency mode

MANILA: Philippine President Ferdinand Marcos Jr. on Tuesday declared a state of national energy emergency to respond to the impact of the Middle East war, which his administration said posed "an imminent danger of a critically low energy supply." Under the declaration, which will initially last for a year, Marcos will lead a contingency committee that will ensure the availability and orderly distribution of fuel, food, medicines, agricultural products and other basic goods.

Authorities were ordered to take action against the hoarding, profiteering and manipulation of the supply of petroleum products. The Department of Migrant Workers, meanwhile, was asked to brace for the possible rescue and evacuation of Filipinos in the Middle East.

The government has started to provide \$83 each to large numbers of motorcycle taxi drivers and other public transport workers nationwide to help them cope with soaring gasoline and diesel prices. AGENCIES

Denmark votes in early election amid US designs on Greenland

COPENHAGEN: Danish voters went to the polls Tuesday in a general election, with Prime Minister Mette Frederiksen seeking a third term at the helm of the Scandinavian country after a standoff with US President Donald Trump over the future of the kingdom's semiautonomous territory of Greenland.

More than 4.3 million people are eligible to have their say in the vote for the new Folketing or parliament, in Copenhagen, which is elected for a



Election officials display empty ballot boxes in Copenhagen

AP

four-year term. Frederiksen called the election in February,

several months before she had to in apparent hopes that her resolute image in the crisis over Greenland would help her with voters in the European Union and NATO member country.

In her second term, her support had waned as the cost of living rose, something that, along with pensions and a potential wealth tax, has been a prominent campaign issue.

The 48-year-old centre-left Social Democrat is known for strong support of Ukraine in its defence against Russia. AGENCIES



Narendra Modi
Hon'ble Prime Minister



सत्यमेव जयते
Government of Delhi



Delhi Tourism



Rekha Gupta
Hon'ble Chief Minister

Government of Delhi Presents

FIRST INTERNATIONAL
FILM FESTIVAL
DELHI

March 25-31, 2026 at Bharat Mandapam

CULTURAL NIGHTS
MASTER CLASSES
NON STOP CINEMA



INTERNATIONAL FILM FESTIVAL DELHI
March 25-31, 2026

125+ FILMS
FILM EXPO
WORK SHOPS
FILM MARKET



Bourses jump nearly 2% as Trump halts strikes on Iran’s energy infra

Investors’ wealth rose by ₹7.56 lakh cr to ₹4,22,78,312.77 cr (\$4.50 trillion)

OUR CORRESPONDENT

MUMBAI: Benchmark stock indices Sensex and Nifty rebounded by nearly 2 per cent on Tuesday, tracking a relief rally in Asian peers after US President Donald Trump announced a temporary halt on strikes targeting Iranian energy infrastructure.

The 30-share BSE Sensex jumped 1,372.06 points or 1.89 per cent to settle at 74,068.45. During the day, it soared 1,793 points or 2.46 per cent to 74,489.39.

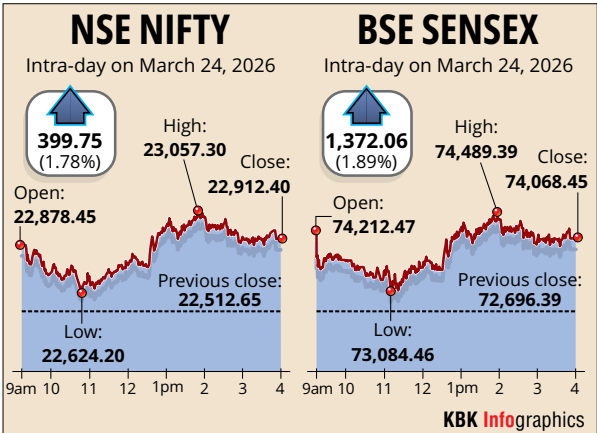
The 50-share NSE Nifty surged 399.75 points or 1.78 per cent to end at 22,912.40.

From the 30-Sensex firms, Larsen & Toubro, InterGlobe Aviation, Eternal, Asian Paints, Bajaj Finance and UltraTech Cement were the biggest winners.

Power Grid and State Bank of India were the only laggards from the pack.

Trump said on social media that he has extended the deadline for Iran to reopen the Strait of Hormuz, the strategically located shipping lane between the Persian Gulf and the Gulf of Oman, and that he will hold off strikes against Iranian energy sites for five days.

Asian markets rebounded, with South Korea’s benchmark Kospi, Japan’s Nikkei 225 index,



From the 30-Sensex firms, Larsen & Toubro, InterGlobe Aviation, Eternal, Asian Paints, Bajaj Finance and UltraTech Cement were the biggest winners

Shanghai’s SSE Composite index and Hong Kong’s Hang Seng index ending sharply higher.

Markets in Europe were trading mostly lower. The US market ended higher on Monday.

Investors’ wealth surged by Rs 7.56 lakh crore to Rs 4,22,78,312.77 crore (\$4.50 trillion). The BSE MidCap Select index jumped 2.77 per cent and SmallCap Select index climbed 2.29 per cent.

All sectoral indices ended higher. Services surged 3.46 per

cent, followed by BSE MidSmall Private Banks Quality Tilt (2.99 per cent), industrials (2.98 per cent), Private Banks index (2.63 per cent), consumer durables (2.46 per cent), Bankex (2.40 per cent), consumer discretionary (2.39 per cent), financial services (2.34 per cent), auto (2.30 per cent) and commodities (2.19 per cent).

A total of 2,968 stocks advanced, while 1,295 declined and 168 remained unchanged on the BSE.

Brent crude, the global oil

Highlights

» Power Grid and State Bank of India were the only laggards from the pack

» The BSE MidCap Select index jumped 2.77% and SmallCap Select index climbed 2.29%

» A total of 2,968 stocks advanced, while 1,295 declined and 168 remained unchanged on the BSE

» FIs offloaded equities worth Rs 10,414.23 crore on Monday, according to exchange data

Rupee falls 23 paise to 93.76 against dollar

MUMBAI: The rupee dropped 23 paise to close at 93.76 against the US dollar on Tuesday as a strengthening greenback against major crosses and elevated global crude prices spooked investors.

Foreign fund outflows amid uncertainties over the West Asia crisis further weighed on the local unit, forex traders said.

At the interbank foreign exchange, the local unit opened at 93.66 against the greenback and remained volatile throughout the session. It eventually settled at 93.76, down 23 paise from its previous close.

The rupee breached the 94-level against the US dollar for the first time on Monday, before closing flat at 93.53.

The dollar index, which gauges the greenback’s strength against a basket of six currencies, was trading 0.23 per cent higher at 99.18.

‘Private sector capex estimated to fall 16.5% to ₹9.55 lakh cr in FY27’

‘The provisional aggregated capex on acquisition of new assets in FY26 is estimated at Rs 11.43 lakh crore’

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Capital expenditure by the private sector on acquisition of new assets is estimated to decline by 16.5 per cent to Rs 9.55 lakh crore in 2026-27, a government survey has said.

As per the survey released by Ministry of Statistics & Programme Implementation, the provisional aggregated capital expenditure on acquisition of new assets in 2025-26 is estimated at Rs 11.43 lakh crore.

Out of the 5,366 operational enterprises that responded to the survey, 4,203 (about 78.3 per cent) reported their capex investment plans for the next financial year (2026-27). Responses were sought from 7,486 enterprises - 5,795 enterprises in the census sector and 1,691 enterprises in sample sector.

Enterprises generally tend to adopt a conservative approach in reporting such estimates for a future year, it stated.

The actual capex incurred during 2024-25 was Rs 173.5 crore per enterprise against an intended Rs 180.2 crore (as reported in the CAPEX-2024 survey), resulting in an overall realisation ratio of 96.3 per cent, it stated.

This indicates that the actual expenditure was broadly in line with the investment intentions at the aggregate level for the



Domestic debt is the second-largest source, contributing 23.25 per cent, followed by equity raised within the country at 3.78%

panel of enterprises, it pointed out.

As per the survey estimates, the strategy of investment for about 48.63 per cent of enterprises during 2025-26 was focused on core assets, while 38.36 per cent planned investments for value addition to existing assets.

Around 14.54 per cent undertook investments in opportunistic assets, less than 4 per cent followed debt-related strategies, and about 1.0 per cent pursued strategies involving distressed assets or non-performing loans.

In addition, 20.15 per cent of enterprises did not report any specific investment strategy from the listed options.

The survey indicated that during 2025-26, about 60.13 per cent of enterprises in the private corporate sector undertook capital expenditure primarily with the objective of income generation, while 42.12 per cent reported CAPEX for upgradation of existing capacity.

Around 7.2 per cent of enterprises incurred capex with the objective of diversification, and about 17.64 per cent reported other reasons not specifically captured in the survey.

The survey results indicate that internal accruals constitute the primary source of capex financing in the private corporate sector during 2025-26, accounting for 65.35 per cent of the total investment.

Domestic debt is the second-largest source, contributing 23.25 per cent, followed by equity raised within the country at 3.78 per cent. External sources play a relatively smaller role, with 1.04 per cent of CAPEX financed through the FDI route and 2.38 per cent through foreign debt, it stated.

The National Statistics Office (NSO) conducted the first such survey during November 2024 to January 2025 to collect information on the capital expenditure plans of enterprises in the private corporate sector.

In continuation of this initiative, the present round of the survey was conducted during October-December 2025.

PSBs transferred ₹60,518 cr unclaimed amount to RBI at end of January 2026

NEW DELHI: The unclaimed amount transferred by public sector banks to the Depositor Education and Awareness Fund of the Reserve Bank of India stood at Rs 60,518 crore at end-January 2026, the Rajya Sabha was informed on Tuesday.

Also, the unclaimed insurance amount outstanding with the insurers was Rs 8,973.89 crore at February-end and the value of unclaimed amounts in mutual funds under SEBI regulations was Rs 3,749.34 crore, MoS for Finance Pankaj Chaudhary said in a written reply to the House.

In order to ensure timely identification of rightful claimants, reducing both the existing stock of unclaimed financial assets as well as the fresh accretion to it and to simplify and



expedite the claim process for citizens, various measures have been undertaken by the financial sector regulators, the minister said.

To another question, the minister said the government has reviewed the investors’ interest in Sovereign Green Bonds (SGRBs). The average bid-cover ratio, an indicator of interest to purchase bond in auction, for SGRBs has so far remained above 2 since inception in FY23. The bid-cover ratio in FY26 stands at 2.32. PFI

Gold jumps ₹1,200 to ₹1.44 lakh/10 grams, silver stays flat

NEW DELHI: Gold prices snapped a four-day losing streak and climbed Rs 1,200 to Rs 1.44 lakh per 10 grams in the national capital on Tuesday, while silver remained flat at Rs 2.30 lakh per kilogram, according to the All India Sarafa Association.

The precious metal of 99.9 per cent purity had closed at Rs 1,43,600 per 10 grams (inclusive of all taxes) on Monday.

Traders attributed the rebound in domestic gold prices to a recovery in global commodity markets and some buying at lower levels after recent sharp declines.

In the international markets, spot gold rebounded after nine sessions of losses, rising \$16.96, or 0.38 per cent, to \$4,423.83 per ounce, while silver was trading 1.03 per cent higher at \$69.86 per ounce.

“Spot gold, after falling for nine straight days, is trading steady at around \$4,420 per ounce in the overseas trade on cautious optimism about the Iran war as the US President Donald Trump declared a five-day ceasefire on strikes against energy installations in Iran,” Praveen Singh, Head of Commodities at Mirae Asset ShareKhan, said.

However, he added that doubts linger over the effectiveness of the ceasefire, keeping investors’ sentiment cautious.

Urea output at 275.75 lakh tonnes in April-Feb FY26

NEW DELHI: India’s urea production stood at 275.75 lakh tonnes in the first eleven months of this fiscal, the government said on Tuesday.

The country’s urea production stood at 306.67 lakh tonnes in the entire 2024-25 fiscal.

“At present, there are 33 Urea manufacturing units in the country with total production capacity of 269.42 lakh tonnes per annum,” the Minister of State for Chemicals and Fertilizers Anupriya Patel said in a written reply to Rajya Sabha.

The government has taken many steps to boost domestic production of urea in the last 11 years, she said.

These steps have “facilitated increase of urea production from level of 225 lakh tonnes per annum during 2014-15

The country’s urea production stood at 306.67 lakh tonnes in the entire 2024-25 fiscal, MoS for Fertilizers Anupriya Patel said

to a record urea production at 314.07 lakh tonnes during 2023-24.

“During 2024-25, 306.67 lakh tonnes of urea was produced in the country,” Patel said.

In reply to a separate query, she said the sales of Nano Urea and Nano DAP during April-January 2025-26 stood at 182.50 lakh bottles and 144.93 lakh bottles (500 ml equivalent), respectively.

Sebi mulling to allow gift cards, PPIs to invest in mutual funds

NEW DELHI: Markets regulator Sebi on Tuesday proposed introducing gift cards or gift prepaid payment instruments (PPIs) for investments in mutual funds to improve financial inclusion through onboarding of new investors in the space.

Under the proposal, the purchaser of Gift PPI can gift the prepaid payment instrument to a recipient, who can then use the instrument to subscribe to mutual fund units, Sebi said in its consultation paper.

These PPIs will be funded only through electronic bank transfer or UPI from an Indian bank account with a validity period of one year from date of issuance.

Sebi suggested a cap of Rs 50,000 per investor per finan-



cial year for investments made through gift PPIs.

“The RTAs, on behalf of AMCs will track how much each investor has invested per AMC per financial year through Gift PPI, e-wallets and cash. If the transaction resulting from a Gift PPI redemption crosses Rs 50,000, the RTA will reject the transaction, and the PPI face value will be refunded to the issuer’s escrow account,” it added.

BRICS summit pushes women-led innovation

NEW DELHI: BRICS Chamber of Commerce and Industry organised 6th BRICS CCI WE Annual Women’s Summit 2026, a three-day event (March 21-23) under theme of Women in Innovation, Science Leadership, Innovation & Entrepreneurship (WISE), focused on strengthening global collaboration and advancing women-led enterprises across BRICS+ nations.

Addressing the summit, Union Minister of State for Youth Affairs and Sports Raksha Khadse said women’s empowerment and youth-led innovation are key to India’s vision of becoming a developed nation by 2047. BRICS CCI WE President Ruby Sinha described the initiative as a shift from inclusion



to leadership, emphasising the need to build stronger ecosystems and support women-led innovation. The WISE platform, launched in 2025, aims to enable cross-border partnerships.

The summit featured B2B meetings, industry visits and a key MoU with Brazil’s SEBRAE to boost MSME cooperation. A leadership programme convocation and a commemorative

publication were also unveiled.

Speakers highlighted the growing role of women in technology and entrepreneurship. BRICS CCI Vice Chairman Sameep Shastri underscored policy support for women in high-tech sectors, while representatives of the BRICS Women’s Business Alliance called for scaling women-led enterprises and improving access to finance.

Speakers highlighted growing role of women in technology and entrepreneurship

Actor Shabana Azmi and Debjani Ghosh stressed the need for greater leadership and decision-making roles for women. Former minister Meenakshi Lekhi unveiled Mission ShakthisAT to promote women’s participation in science and space. The summit concluded with multiple recognitions, reflecting growing momentum in women-led innovation and leadership across BRICS economies.

IPO boom holds strong despite global oil shock, market volatility

Overall, 204 firms raised Rs 1.70 lakh crore through IPOs so far this fiscal, broadly matching last year’s fundraising

NEW DELHI: India’s primary market activity remained robust in FY26 even as a sharp global energy shock and rising geopolitical tensions unsettled financial markets, according to NSE’s Market Pulse: March 2026.

Mainboard IPO momentum stayed strong, with 99 listings between April and February raising Rs 1.65 lakh crore—surpassing last year’s 79 issues that mobilised Rs 1.62 lakh crore. In contrast, SME IPO activity moderated, with 105 issues raising Rs 5,121 crore versus 163 issues and over Rs 7,000 crore in FY25.

Overall, 204 companies raised Rs 1.70 lakh crore



through IPOs so far this fiscal, broadly matching last year’s fundraising despite fewer listings. The SME segment, however, showed signs of maturity, with average issue size rising to about Rs 50 crore from Rs 13 crore in FY20.

CLOSER LOOK

» Mainboard IPO momentum stayed strong, with 99 listings between April & Feb raising Rs 1.65 lakh cr—surpassing last year’s 79 issues that mobilised Rs 1.62 lakh crore

» SME IPO activity moderated, with 105 issues raising Rs 5,121 cr against 163 issues & over Rs 7,000 cr in FY25

» Investor participation continued to expand, with NSE’s registered base reaching 12.8 crore in February

Investor participation continued to expand, with NSE’s registered base reaching 12.8 crore in February, led by strong youth engagement. Investors below 30 years accounted for over 38 per cent of the base

and more than half of new additions, while Maharashtra became the first state to cross 2 crore investors.

The strong domestic market activity comes amid heightened global uncertainty. Crude oil prices surged past \$100 per barrel following the escalation

of the Iran-Israel-US conflict, triggering a broad risk-off sentiment. Global equities corrected sharply in March, with MSCI World and emerging market indices falling 5 per cent and 8.8 per cent, respectively, while commodities strengthened and emerging market currencies weakened.

Indian equities mirrored the trend, with the Nifty 50 declining 8.1 per cent in March and 11.4 per cent year-to-date as of mid-March. Foreign investors resumed selling, though domestic institutional inflows provided some cushion.

Despite external headwinds, India’s macroeconomic funda-

mentals remain resilient. GDP growth stood at 7.8 per cent year-on-year in Q3 FY26, supported by strong consumption, investment and services activity. High-frequency indicators such as GST collections, credit growth and PMI data remain robust.

However, rising crude prices pose risks to inflation and the current account deficit, complicating the policy outlook. The evolving global environment, coupled with energy-driven uncertainties, is likely to shape market conditions in the near term, even as India’s growth trajectory remains broadly intact.

RBI injects ₹55,837 cr in banking system via 3-day variable rate repo auction

MUMBAI: The Reserve Bank of India (RBI) on Tuesday injected Rs 55,837 crore transient liquidity into the banking system through three-day variable rate repo (VRR) auction.

The RBI injected the funds at cut-off and weighted average rates of 5.26 per cent, the central bank said in a release.

The liquidity injected was much lower than the notified amount of Rs 1 lakh crore, despite the sharp drop in surplus liquidity in the banking system due to advance tax

payments. Currently, liquidity in the banking system is estimated to be in surplus of about Rs 26,196.36 crore as on March 23.

In the last few days, the central bank infused transient liquidity of Rs 2,08,208 crore into the banking system through VRR auctions of various tenures. Prior to this, the RBI infused Rs 3.50 lakh crore of durable liquidity into the banking system through open market purchase (OMO) of government securities since January 2026.

Employment in unincorporated sector rises 6.18% in 2025: Report

‘Number of workers in unincorporated sector rose to 12,80,51,800 in 2025 from 12,05,99,800 during October 2023–September 2024 period’

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Employment grew 6.18 per cent to 12.80 crore in the unincorporated enterprises sector in 2025, adding more than 74.52 lakh new jobs during the period, according to a government survey.

The Annual Survey of Unincorporated Sector Enterprises (ASUSE) for 2025, released on Tuesday, showed that the number of workers in the unincorporated sector rose to 12,80,51,800 in 2025 from 12,05,99,800 during the October 2023–September 2024 period.

The Ministry of Statistics and Programme Implementation (MoSPI) has released the results of ASUSE for 2025 for the reference period January 2025 - December 2025, referred to as ASUSE 2025.

The total number of establishments in the sector increased substantially from 7.34 crore in ASUSE 2023-24 (October 23 – September 24) to 7.92 crore in ASUSE 2025 (January 2025 -December 2025), representing a healthy 7.97 per cent growth.

Among the broad sectors covered, the number of establishments in the “Other Services” sector recorded a robust



The total number of establishments in the sector jumped substantially from 7.34 crore in ASUSE 2023-24 (October 23 – September 24) to 7.92 crore in ASUSE 2025 (January 2025 — December 2025)

growth of 10.29 per cent, followed by a 6.48 per cent increase witnessed by the manufacturing sector and 6.18 per cent by the trade sector.

This increase reflects broad-based expansion across sectors and highlights the steady growth of the unincorporated non-agricultural sector.

During the same period, the gross value added (GVA), which is a key indicator of economic performance, surged 10.87 per cent, driven by 16.77 per cent growth in the trade

sector, followed by 8.52 per cent growth in manufacturing and 7.36 per cent in other services sectors.

Among the broad sectors, however, the other services sector had the highest share in GVA (42 per cent), followed by trade (37 per cent) and manufacturing (21 per cent).

Gross Value Added (GVA) per worker, which is a measure of labour productivity of the sector, rose to Rs 1,56,539 in 2025 from Rs 1,49,742 in 2023-24 in current prices, showing a

Highlights

» The sector employed about 12.81 crore workers during January-December 2025, adding over 74.52 lakh jobs from 2023-24 (Oct 2023 – Sept 2024)

» ‘Other Services’ sector showed highest rise of 7.40%, generating 35 lakh new employment

» Percentage of female-owned proprietary establishments rose from 26.2% in 2023–24 to 27% in ASUSE 2025

4.54 per cent increase.

During the same period, the Gross Value Added (GVA) per establishment also increased from Rs 2,45,687 to Rs 2,52,699.

About the labour market performance, it stated the sector employed about 12.81 crore workers during January-December 2025, adding more than 74.52 lakh jobs from 2023-24 (October 2023 - September 2024), reflecting robust labour market expansion.

Among the broad activities, the “Other Services” sector

showed the highest growth of 7.40 per cent, generating about 35 lakh new employment. The percentage of female-owned proprietary establishments increased marginally from 26.2 per cent in 2023–24 to 27 per cent in ASUSE 2025, pointing to an encouraging trend in women-led enterprises.

The emolument per hired worker increased by 3.88 per cent in 2025 compared to the previous ASUSE 2023-24, signalling improvements in wage levels. The highest increase in this metric was observed in the trade sector, which recorded a growth of about 8.5 per cent.

About the digital penetration, it stated that the percentage of establishments using the internet has also grown significantly from 26.7 per cent in 2023-24 to 39.4 per cent in ASUSE 2025.

This substantial growth reflects a strong trend toward digital adoption among establishments, highlighting the increasing reliance on the internet for business operations. In ASUSE 2025, data were collected from a total of 6,70,289 establishments (2,94,144 in rural and 3,76,145 in urban), pertaining to 24,153 surveyed First Stage Units (10,219 in rural and 13,934 in urban).

Oil industry pushing for ethanol to cut dependency on LPG imports

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The petroleum industry on Tuesday urged industry players to develop ethanol as a clean cooking fuel for Indian households as part of efforts to reduce dependence on imported LPG and expand biofuel use.

R S Ravi, Director (Downstream) at the Federation of Indian Petroleum Industry (FIPI), made the appeal while addressing the All India Distillers’ Association (AIDA) conference, highlighting ongoing research into ethanol-based cooking stoves. “A lot of work is happening” at agencies like the LPG Equipment Research Centre (LERC) and various IITs to develop ethanol-compatible and efficient cooking stoves, with prototypes likely to be ready soon, Ravi said.

He sought active support from the All India Distillers Association (IDA) and its members on two key fronts: connecting with manufacturers to scale up production of these stoves, and more importantly, developing a viable supply chain to deliver ethanol directly to households. “This is a different ballgame. As of now, the way you are supporting the oil industry is by supplying bulk... It needs to change,” Ravi stated.

“How this supply chain is going to be developed, what form it needs to be delivered, the form factor is very critical.”

He added, “Can AIDA come forward and give us ideas in terms of how we make this ethanol as a cooking fuel possible



Research institutions are already working on ethanol stoves as a cleaner alternative that could complement or partially replace LPG, in rural and semi-urban areas

in India?”

Ravi’s remarks came against the backdrop of India’s successful rollout of 20 per cent ethanol blending (E20) in petrol. He credited the distillery industry for enabling the programme and a recent government notification mandating the sale of E20 petrol with a minimum Research Octane Number (RON) of 95 from April 1, 2026.

The shift to higher-octane E20 petrol is expected to improve vehicle power output and efficiency while addressing past concerns over lower-octane blends. Ravi also made two other requests to the ethanol industry — accelerating

production of isobutanol (IBA) for blending in diesel and developing technological readiness for ethanol-to-Sustainable Aviation Fuel (SAF) routes -- but laid special emphasis on the cooking fuel initiative.

Research institutions are already working on ethanol stoves as a cleaner alternative that could complement or partially replace LPG, particularly in rural and semi-urban areas.

The FIPI official noted that transitioning ethanol from bulk industrial supply to household-level distribution would require innovative logistics, suitable packaging or dispensing formats, and last-mile delivery mechanisms.

India has been aggressively pushing ethanol blending in petrol to cut crude oil imports, save foreign exchange, reduce emissions, and support farmers.

Extending the biofuel ecosystem to cooking fuel could further diversify ethanol demand and enhance energy security. Ravi called for collaborative efforts between the oil industry and distillers to make ethanol-based cooking a practical reality in the country.

IBC resolution boosts sales, valuation of cos

The study found that avg sales of resolved firms increased by 89% in the five years after resolution, indicating a substantial revival in business activities

NEW DELHI: Firms resolved under the Insolvency and Bankruptcy Code (IBC) have witnessed improvement in their financial and operational performance, with strong gains in sales & asset turnover, according to a study by IIM Ahmedabad.

The research study builds upon an earlier study undertaken in 2023, which analysed firms in the post-resolution period for the years 2013–2022.

The study seeks to update and broaden the analysis by extending the coverage up to 2025 to capture the most recent developments. A total of 1194 firms that underwent the resolution process were part of this study, according to a release.

The study found that average sales of resolved firms increased

Asset utilisation also improved significantly, with the asset turnover ratio rising by about 131% during the same period

by 89 per cent in the five years after resolution, indicating a substantial revival in business activities. Asset utilisation also improved significantly, with the asset turnover ratio rising by about 131 per cent during the same period.

According to the study, capital expenditure (capex) by these firms saw a notable rise of

around 106 per cent over five years, reflecting renewed investment activity and improved economic viability. The average asset base also expanded, growing from Rs 228.33 crore in the resolution year to Rs 254.60 crore in the fifth-year post-resolution, marking an increase of around 11.5 per cent, the Insolvency and Bankruptcy Board of India (IBBI) said.

Market capitalisation of resolved firms also recorded a sharp recovery. The aggregate market valuation rose from around Rs 2.8 lakh crore to Rs 9 lakh crore during a five-year period, reflecting improved investor confidence and growth prospects, following successful resolution with creditors, it added.

Further, liquidity levels improved considerably with an increase of approximately 106 per cent, signalling improved financial health and short-term solvency of the resolved firms, the board said. The study noted that the improvements across key financial and operational indicators under the effectiveness of the IBC framework in reviving distressed firms.

The resolution process has enabled firms to restore long-term viability, attract fresh investments, and enhance overall productivity. The findings also assume significance as the IBC completes a decade since its enactment, offering empirical insights on its role in strengthening the corporate insolvency resolution process, it added. PTI

Jindal Steel doubles Angul plant capacity to 12 mn tonnes/annum

NEW DELHI: Jindal Steel on Tuesday said it has doubled the steel making capacity of its Angul facility to 12 million tonnes per annum.

With this expansion, Angul has become one the largest single-location steel plants in India, taking Jindal Steel’s overall capacity to 15.6 million tonnes per annum (MTPA).

In an exchange filing, the company said it has fully operationalised the expansion of its Angul plant capacity from 6 MTPA to 12 MTPA within the planned timeframe.

Post this expansion, the company’s overall crude steel capacity has increased to 15.6 MTPA, including 3.6 MTPA at

Post this expansion, company’s overall crude steel capacity has jumped to 15.6 MTPA, including 3.6 MTPA at its Raigarh facility

its Raigarh facility. Jindal Steel said the expanded capacity is expected to drive higher volumes and improve capacity utilisation, supporting revenue growth while delivering operating leverage benefits.

The company is well positioned to enhance margins,

optimise costs, and improve profitability, while strengthening domestic steel capacity in line with India’s nation-building priorities and the vision of Atmanirbhar Bharat.

However, Jindal Steel did not provide any financial details.

As per industry estimates, an investment of Rs 5,000-6,000 crore is required to set up one million tonne steel plant.

Jindal Steel caters to key sectors, including infrastructure, construction, railways, automotive, energy, industrial manufacturing, defence, and white goods with supplies of value-added steel products from Angul (Odisha) and Raigarh (Chhattisgarh) facilities. MPOST

HDFC Bank appoints external law firms to review issues cited in former chairman’s letter

NEW DELHI: HDFC Bank has appointed external law firms to independently examine the issues highlighted in the resignation letter by Atanu Chakraborty as part of a proactive step to ensure an objective and fact-based assessment.

The bank’s spokesperson said the appointment of external law firms is a proactive measure taken by the bank to independently look at the aspects mentioned in the letter so as to ensure an objective and fact-based assessment.

This step is aimed at constantly benchmarking against the highest governance standards that the bank has practiced over decades, the spokesperson added.



It is to be noted that Atanu Chakraborty abruptly resigned as chairman of the country’s second biggest lender HDFC Bank citing ethical concerns effective March 18.

This is the first time that the part-time chairman of HDFC Bank left mid-way raising concerns over its functioning.

“Certain happenings and practices within the bank, that I have observed over the last two years, are not in congru-

ence with my personal Values and Ethics. This is the basis of my aforementioned decision,” he said in his resignation letter dated March 17.

In a letter addressed to Chairman of Governance, Nomination, Remuneration Committee H K Bhanwala, Chakraborty said that “there are no other material reasons for my resignation other than those stated above.”

It is to be noted that Chakraborty was appointed part-time chairman effective May 5, 2021 almost a year after retirement as Economic Affairs Secretary.

His term was extended for another three years in 2024 till May 4, 2027.

Chakraborty, a 1985 batch IAS officer of Gujarat cadre, retired as Secretary of Department of Economic Affairs in April 2020. Prior to that, he was Secretary of the Department of Investment and Public Asset Management (DIPAM). Both departments come under the Finance Ministry.

Chakraborty became chairman during the reverse merger process of the bank with the parent entity HDFC Ltd, a leading mortgage firm in the country.

The merger of HDFC Ltd. with HDFC Bank became effective on July 1, 2023, creating a financial behemoth with a combined balance sheet of over Rs 18 lakh crore. PTI

Govt extends validity of TRQ license for gold imports under trade pact with UAE

NEW DELHI: The government on Tuesday extended the validity of licences issued for gold import at quota-based duty concession under a free trade pact with the UAE till June 3 amid the West Asian crisis.

Under the India-UAE comprehensive economic partnership agreement (CEPA), India has granted quota-based duty concessions on gold imports under the tariff rate quota (TRQ).

“In view of the prevailing geopolitical develop-

ments affecting global trade and logistics, and with a view to facilitating importers, the Director General of Foreign Trade, hereby extends the validity of TRQ Authorisations issued in the financial year 2025-26, for import of Gold, issued under the India-UAE CEPA, from the existing validity of March 31, 2026 up to June 30, 2026,” a government public notice said.

The India-UAE comprehensive economic partnership agreement came into force in 2022. PTI

NCLAT declines to stay Vedanta plea against nod to Adani’s JAL bid

The NCLAT’s two-member bench sought a response from the Committee of Creditors (CoC) of JAL within a week

NEW DELHI: The National Company Law Appellate Tribunal (NCLAT) on Tuesday refused to grant an interim stay on the Vedanta Group’s plea challenging the NCLT’s approval of Adani Enterprises Ltd’s Rs 14,535 crore bid for acquiring Jaiprakash Associates Ltd (JAL).

A two-member bench of the appellate tribunal directed the Committee of Creditors (CoC) of JAL to file its response within a week and scheduled the next hearing for April 10.

The tribunal noted that all parties agreed on the need for an expedited hearing given the

CLOSER LOOK

» Last week, the National Company Law Tribunal (NCLT) approved the Adani Group’s bid

» Challenging the NCLT order, the Vedanta group has filed two appeals before the NCLAT

» In first one, it has challenged the validity of the resolution plan & in the second one, it has challenged the approval of plan by CoC & adjudicating authority (NCLT)

nature of the dispute.

While declining interim relief, the bench clarified that implementation of the resolution plan may continue but will remain subject to the final outcome of Vedanta’s appeals.

It also recorded submissions from the CoC that any delisting of JAL under the approved plan would automatically stand cancelled if the tribunal later sets aside the order.

Vedanta has filed two

appeals before the NCLAT—one challenging the validity of the resolution plan and the other contesting its approval by both the CoC and the National Company Law Tribunal (NCLT), which cleared Adani’s bid on March 17.

During the hearing, Vedanta argued that it had offered a higher bid of Rs 16,726 crore and was initially declared the highest bidder by the CoC.

It contended that the insolvency process must prioritise value maximisation under the Insolvency and Bank-

ruptcy Code, and alleged that the lenders failed to ensure a fair and transparent bidding process.

The CoC, however, defended its decision, stating that the process complied with all regulatory norms and that evaluation was based on multiple parameters, including upfront cash, feasibility and execution timelines—not just the headline bid value.

Adani’s proposal was preferred as it offered around Rs 6,000 crore upfront and faster payments within two years, compared to Vedanta’s longer payment schedule.

Lenders also rejected Vedanta’s revised offer, saying it was submitted after the bidding process had closed and accepting it would have required restarting the process.

JAL was admitted into insolvency proceedings in June 2024 after defaulting on loans aggregating Rs 57,185 crore.

The company has diversified interests across real estate, cement, hospitality, power and infrastructure, including marquee projects such as Jaypee Greens and the Jaypee International Sports City in the NCR region. AGENCIES

Elangovan shines in indoor c'ships

BHUBANESWAR: Seasoned Tamil Nadu athlete Baranica Elangovan smashed the overall national record in women's pole vault event in a stunning performance, clearing a height of 4.22m on the opening day of the National Indoor Championships here on Tuesday.

The 29-year-old Baranica, a three-time national outdoor champion, cleared 4.22m to better the earlier national record of 4.21m which has been in the name of Rosy Meena Paulraj since 2022.

Before Baranica's feat on Tuesday, there was no official national indoor record for women's pole vault as this is the inaugural national championships.

Blessy Kunjumon (3.95m) and Mariya Jaison (3.380m), both of Kerala, were second and third respectively.

The 4.22m mark of Baranica will now be the national indoor as well as the overall record, and it will just be a formality for the Athletics Federation of India (AFI) to ratify it. The officers of the National Anti-Doping Agency (NADA) took samples from her for dope test after her event, a requirement for ratification of national records.

She went on to further improve her national record but failed three times when the bar was raised to 4.25m.

"I have major competitions ahead and was focusing only on the techniques. It worked for me and I am really happy with that. I was mainly focusing on the runway approach only. Previously, I was struggling with the runway," said Baranica after her feat.

She credited her coach Milber Bertrand Russell, who has been with her since 2016, for her feat.

Baranica, who is currently with the Reliance Foundation High Performance Centre in Bhubaneswar after shifting base from Chennai in 2023, had made a remarkable comeback from an Anterior Cruciate Ligament (ACL) surgery on her left leg in 2020.

"I also had ACL surgery in 2020 and it's been reconstructed. After that I was doing rehab and it was quite hard, it was up and down. All this time I was having pain on and off."

She said competing indoors is an advantage for pole vaulters as there is no impact of wind.

"Wind is a major factor in pole vault. If you are taking the pole high and if you are having the heavy wind against you, it will be very difficult for you to move forward and attack the last stride approaching the runway. But here, you won't be having that much thing as there is no wind indoors. You won't worry anything and you can approach easily. So, it's an advantage for pole vaulters."

In other events, local athlete Sarun Payasingh won the men's long jump gold with a personal best effort of 7.80m.

The 25-year-old Payasingh beat triple jump national record holder Praveen Chithravel of Tamil Nadu, who was competing in long jump here.

Chithravel, who was representing JSW, made only three attempts and left after a best effort of 7.78m which fetched him a silver.

AGENCIES

OFFICE OF THE CHIEF ENGINEER INDORE PUBLIC WORKS DEPARTMENT, INDORE Opp. Gayatri Mandir, Old Palasia Indore-452001 Email: cepwdwest@mp.nic.in Phone: 0731-2491825 NIT No. 18/Gen/40/2025-26 Indore, dated 18/03/2026

"Notice Inviting Tender"

Online tender in three envelope system is hereby invited for the following work. Details of works can be seen on the website <http://mptenders.gov.in>

No.	Portal No.	District	Name of work	Probable amount of Contract (In Lacs)	Amount of EMD (In Rs.)	Cost of Tender form (In Rs.)	Time allowed for completion
1.	2026.PWD RB_491481	Indore	Construction of Veterinary Road Nahar To Naag Mandir Harsola Road Length 04.50km. i/c Electric Pole Shifting Work.	521.03	521030/-	20000/-	12 Month's including rainy Season
2.	2026.PWD RB_491482	Indore	Construction of Lalkhedha Kayashbedi Khandewal Warehouse Bypass Road Length 04.00km. i/c Electric Pole Shifting Work. (Second Called)	782.30	782300/-	20000/-	12 Month's including rainy Season
3.	2026.PWD RB_491483	Indore	Construction of Ajnod To Palaskriya Baloda Takum Road Length 07.20km. i/c Electric Pole Shifting Work. (Second Called)	772.69	772690/-	20000/-	12 Month's including rainy Season
4.	2026.PWD RB_491484	Indore	Construction of Single Lane Road from Methwada, Pipripliya to Karwasa Road Length 06.00km. i/c Electric Pole Shifting Work. (Second Called)	668.13	668130/-	20000/-	12 Month's including rainy Season
5.	2026.PWD RB_491485	Alirajpur	Construction of Andharichand Patel Palga To Gujrat Sima Tak Road Length 05.10km. i/c Electric Pole Shifting Work. (Second Called)	722.05	722050/-	20000/-	12 Month's including rainy Season
Total-				3466.20 Lacs			

The document can only be purchased online from the above website after making online payment. The last date & time for purchase of document and bid submission online is dated 06.04.2026 up to 17:30. Detailed NIT and other details can be viewed on the above-mentioned portal. Amendments to NIT, if any would be published on website only, and not in newspaper. Submit all the mandatory documents online on above mentioned website. Do not submit any physical document in the office..

Sd/- Chief Engineer
P.W.D. Indore, Zone Indore

G27803/25

NORTHERN RAILWAY

NOTICE INVITING QUOTATION

Name of work: - Proposal for calling of quotations for the work of preparation of tender drawings, tender documents, and specifications for the EPC tender for the work of "Setting up of Trainset Depot for maintenance of Vande Bharat Sleeper Trains in compliance with WTA-527 at Shakurbasti, Delhi," including all other allied works for Northern Railway.

The terms and conditions of above works are as follows:-

1. The above noted work should be completed within 45 days.
2. The concerned contractor while filling the quotation should submit the earnest money amounting to Rs.19700/- in the form of DD/FDR in favour of FA&CAO/C, Kashmir Gate, Delhi-06.
3. The concerned contractor after receiving the LOA will deposit the Performance Guarantee of 5% of the accepted value in form of FDR/BG in the name of FA&CAO/C Kashmir Gate, Delhi within 21 days of issuing date of LOA in the office of Dy.CME/C/K.Gate/DLI.
4. The value of the performance Guarantee will be refund after completion of the work.
5. It is requested to the quotationers, that they must submit their quotations on the prescribed performa at this office till 14:00 hours on 31.03.2026 which will be opened on 01.04.2026.

Note: - Performa of the quotation can be obtained in any working days from 10:00 hours till 14:00 Hours from the date 24.03.2026 till 31.03.2026 from the office of Dy. Chief Mechanical Engineer/Construction, Kashmir Gate/NR. No.01/CPM/HTS & Const./NR/2025-26

992/2026

SERVING CUSTOMERS WITH A SMILE

Muthoot Homefin (India) Ltd.
CIN : U65922KL2011PLC029231
Corporate Office : Muthoot Homefin (INDIA) Ltd. 19/E, The Ruby, SenapatiBapat Marg, Tulsī Pipe Road, Near Ruparel College, Dadar West, Mumbai - 400028.
Branch Office: C/o, Muthoot Finance Ltd, 01st floor, SI 12 Ghaziabad- 201002 , Uttar Pradesh

APPENDIX-IV-A [See proviso to Rule 8(6)]

PUBLIC NOTICE FOR PRIVATE TREASURY CUM SALE

Pursuant to taking possession of the secured asset mentioned hereunder by the Authorized Officer of Muthoot Homefin (India) Ltd. under the Securitization and Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act, 2002 for the recovery of amount due from borrower/s, offers are invited by the undersigned in sealed covers for purchase of immovable property, as described hereunder, which is in the possession, on 'As Is Where Is Basis', 'As Is What Is Basis' and 'Whatever Is There Is Basis', Particulars of which are given below:-

Sr. No.	Borrower(s)/ Co-Borrower(s)/ Guarantor(s) / Loan Account No. / Branch	Demand Notice Date and Amount	Description of the Immovable property	Reserve Price	Earnest Money Deposit (EMD) (10% of RP)
1.	Manik sarkar/ Saptami Sarkar/ 056-05600098/ Ghaziabad	15-Mar-21/ Rs. 3,31,121/-Rupees Three Lakh Thirty One Thousand One Hundred Twenty One Only.	Plot No. 1555, Khasra No. 9 Min,sudram Enclave, Alvardipur, Noidag B Nagaruttar Pradesh- 201301. More Particularly Mentioned In The Sale Deed Registered No. 4006-2018 Dated- 04-jun-18 In The Office of Sub Registrar Gautam Budh Nagar. Having Boundaries- North- Other Plot, South- Other Plot, East- other Plot, West- Road 18ft	Rs. 3,50,000/- Rupees Three Lakh Fifty Thousand Only.	Rs. 35,000/- Rupees Thirty Five Thousand Only.

1. The Auction is being held on "AS IS WHERE IS" AND "AS IS WHAT IS" basis
 2. The detailed terms and conditions of the auction sale are incorporated in the prescribed tender form, available at the above mentioned regional office
 3. Last Date of Submission of Sealed Bid/Offer in the prescribed tender forms along with EMD payable by way of Demand Draft in Favor of 'Muthoot Homefin (India) Ltd'. along with KYC in on 14-Apr-2026 till 04:00 PM at Regional Office the address mentioned herein above. Tenders that are not filled up completely or tenders received beyond last date will be considered as invalid tender and shall accordingly be rejected. No interest shall be paid on the EMD.
 4. Date of Inspection of the Immovable Property is on 13-Apr-2026 between 01:00 P.M. to 03:00 P.M.
 5. Date of Opening of the Bid/Offer Auction Date for Property is 15-Apr-2026 at the above mentioned Branch Office address at 01:00 PM. by the Authorised Officer.
 6. The MHIL shall not be responsible for payment of any outstanding statutory notice & Encumbrances / taxes arrears etc. if any & their Responsible to pay the sum would be that of the Successful auction purchase. The Intending bidder should make their own independent inquiries regarding the Encumbrances Title of property & also inspect & satisfy themselves.
 7. The Highest bidder shall be subject to approval of MHIL Ltd. Authorised Officer shall Reserve the right to accept all any of the offer /Bid so received without assign any reason whatsoever. His decision shall be final and binding.
 8. The Borrower(s)/Guarantor(s) are hereby given 15 DAYS SALE NOTICE UNDER THE SARFAESI ACT, 2002 to pay the sum mentioned as above before the date of Auction failing which the immovable property will be auctioned and balance, if any, will be recovered with interest and costs. If the Borrower pays the amount due to Muthoot Homefin (India) Ltd., in full, before the date of sale, auction is liable to be set aside.
- For further details, contact the Authorised Officer, at the above mentioned Office address Contact Person- Deepanshu Soni- 9888441449
Date : March 25, 2026,
Place: Gautam Budh Nagar

Sd/- Authorized Officer,
Muthoot Homefin (India) Limited



Branch Office: ICICI Bank Ltd. 3rd Floor Shal Tower, New Rohtak Road, Karol Bagh, Delhi- 110005

PUBLIC NOTICE-TENDER CUM E-AUCTION FOR SALE OF SECURED ASSET

[See proviso to rule 8(6)]
Notice for sale of immovable assets

E-Auction Sale Notice for the sale of immovable asset(s) under the Securitisation and Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act, 2002 read with proviso to Rule 8 (6) of the Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules, 2002.

This notice is hereby given to the public in general and in particular to the Borrower(s) and Guarantor(s) that the below described immovable property mortgaged/ charged to the Secured Creditor, the physical possession of which has been taken by the Authorised Officer of ICICI Bank Limited will be sold on 'As is where is', 'As is what is' and 'Whatever there is' as per the brief particulars given hereunder;

Sr. No.	Name of Borrower(s)/ Co-Borrowers/ Guarantors/ Loan Account No.	Details of the Secured asset(s) with known encumbrances, if any	Amount Outstanding	Reserve Price/ Earnest Money Deposit	Date and Time of Property Inspection	Date & Time of E-Auction
(A)	(B)	(C)	(D)	(E)	(F)	(G)
1.	Kadambini Jaiswal (Applicant), Proveen Gupta (Co Applicant), Lan No. LBDE00004578690	House No. D-83 (Without Roof Right), Ground Floor, Situated At Sector-4 (T.H.A), Residential Colony Lajpat Nagar, Tehsil And District Ghaziabad, Uttar Pradesh- 201005 (Admeasuring An Area of Total Area 37.97 Sq. Mtr. Covered Area 32.540 Sq. Mtr.	Rs. 22,15,415/- As on March 20, 2026	Rs. 15,30,000/- Rs. 1,53,000/-	April 07, 2026 From 03:00 PM- 05:00 PM	April 17, 2026 From 11:00 AM- 12:00 Noon

The online auction will be conducted on the website URL Link-<https://disposalhub.com> of our auction agency M/s NexXen Solutions Private Limited. The Mortgage/ Notices are given a last chance to pay the total dues with further interest by April 16, 2026 before 05:00 PM else the secured asset(s) will be sold as per schedule. The prospective bidder(s) must submit the Earnest Money Deposit (EMD) Demand Draft (DD) (Refer Column E) at ICICI Bank Ltd. 3rd Floor Shal Tower, New Rohtak Road, Karol Bagh, Delhi-110005 on or before April 16, 2026 before 05:00 PM Thereafter, they have to submit their offer through the website mentioned above on or before April 16, 2026 before 05:00 PM along with the scanned image of the Bank acknowledged DD towards proof of payment of EMD. In case the prospective bidder(s) is/ are unable to submit his/ her/ their offer through the website, then the signed copy of tender documents may be submitted at ICICI Bank Ltd. 3rd Floor Shal Tower, New Rohtak Road, Karol Bagh, Delhi-110005 on or before April 16, 2026 before 05:00 PM. Earnest Money Deposit D/D/PO should be from a Nationalised/ Scheduled Bank in favour of 'ICICI Bank Limited' payable at Delhi. For any further clarifications in terms of inspection, Terms and Conditions of the E-Auction or submission of tenders, contact ICICI Bank Employee Phone No. 8928935040/8584874809. Please note that Marketing agencies 1. M/s NexXen Solutions Private Limited, 2. Augoe Assets Management Private Limited 3. Motex Net Pvt. Ltd. 4. Finvin Estate Deal Technologies Pvt Ltd 5. Girsarsoft Pvt Ltd 6. Hecto Proag Tech Pvt Ltd 7. Arco Armat Pvt Ltd 8. Novel Asset Service Pvt Ltd 9. Nobroker Technologies Solutions Pvt Ltd 10. Value Trust Capital Services Private Limited, have also been engaged for facilitating the sale of this property. The Authorised Officer reserves the right to reject any or all the bids without furnishing any further reasons. For Detailed Terms and Conditions of the sale, please visit www.icicibank.com/n4p4s

Date : March 25, 2026
Place: Ghaziabad/NCR

NORTH CENTRAL RAILWAY

TENDER NOTICE

Date: 23.03.2026

Sr. Divisional Electrical Engineer (General) N. C. Railway, Agra on behalf of President of India invites "Open Tender" through on line only (E-Tendering) for the following works.

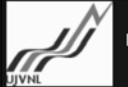
Tender No.: T-13-N-2025-26 **Approx Cost of the work :** Rs. 5617298.00

Name of work with its location & Completion Period : (A) Provision of Replacement of old and damaged LED fitting over Agra Division. (B) Provision of window and Split type AC over Agra Division. Completion period 08 months

For full details and submission of bid please see the Indian Railways website www.ireps.gov.in

Tenders can only be submitted through web portal www.ireps.gov.in up to 15:00 hrs. on 15.04.2026 **657/26 (D)**

www.northcentralrailways.gov.in @ CPORNCR @ www.ncr.indianrailways.gov.in



UJVN LIMITED

H.O.: "UJJWAL", Maharani Bagh, G.M.S. Road, Dehradun-248006
Telephones: 0135-2763808, Fax: 0135-2763508
CIN No. U40101UR2001SGC025866 Website: www.ujvn.com

Letter No: 247 **Short Term Tender Notice** Date: 24/03/2026

Office of the Executive Engineer (E&M), Asan Barrage, 'Jai Shakti Bhawan', Dhakrani invites sealed tenders from interested parties. Brief summary of tender is given below:

Tender No. NIT No.: (1) T-12/EE (E&M)/ Asan Barrage/ (2025-26) & (2) T-13/EE (E&M)/Asan Barrage/ (2025-26)

Name of work/supply/services etc.: (1) Hiring of 01 nos. non-AC diesel vehicle along with Driver for EE (E&M), Asan Barrage, Dhalipur for a period of one year. & (2) Work of refilling of fire extinguishers at Asan Barrage, Dhalipur.

Estimated cost: (1) ₹ 4,86,101.00 only GST extra. & (2) ₹ 5,67,012.00 only GST extra.

Date of availability of bid document on website: 25/03/2026.

Last date for submission of bids: 08/04/2026 upto 13:00 hrs.

For fuller & further details, kindly visit our website. The tender documents can be downloaded from the Nigam's website "www.ujvn.com"

Executive Engineer (E&M)

"AVOID WASTEFUL USE OF ELECTRICITY"

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

See Section 82 Cr.P.C.

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused **Sanjay, S/o:** Vishvnath Shah, R/o: D-72, Ph-2, Indra Enclave, New Delhi has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in case **FIR No. 253/2021 U/s 33/52 Delhi Excise Act, P.S.: Tigri, New Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused **Sanjay** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused **Sanjay** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant).

Proclamation is hereby made that the said **Sanjay** accused of offence in case **FIR No. 253/2021 U/s 33/52 Delhi Excise Act, P.S.: Tigri, New Delhi** and is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before **25.04.2026**.

By Order

Sh. Chatinder Singh

Judicial Magistrate First Class-04
Room No. 211, Saket Court, New Delhi

DP/3807/SD/2026
(Court Matter)

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSONS

See Section 82 CrPc / 84 Bhartiya Nagarik

Suraksha Sanhita, 2023

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused persons (1) **Santosh S/o** Vidya Sagar (2) **Ganesh S/o** Muneshwar Dass R/o. Jhuggi No. 1329, Lohiya Camp, Haiderpur, Delhi, has committed (or are suspected to have committed) the offence in **FIR No. 509/2020, U/S 129/55 G. Act, PS Shalimar Bagh, North-West Distt., Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused (1) **Santosh** (2) **Ganesh** cannot be found, and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused (1) **Santosh** (2) **Ganesh** has absconded (or are concealing themselves to avoid the service of the said warrant).

Proclamation is hereby made that (1) **Santosh** (2) **Ganesh** the said accused of **FIR No. 509/2020, U/S 129/55 G. Act, PS Shalimar Bagh, North-West Distt., Delhi**, is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before **16.05.2026**.

By Order

Sh. Gaurav Katiyari

Judicial Magistrate First Class-07,
North-West Distt., Court No.-08,
2nd Floor, Rohini Courts, Delhi

DP/3827/NW/2026
(Court Matter)

Public Work Department
Office of the Executive Engineer Public Works (West)
Division Chhatrapati Sambhajanagar
Address :- Public Works Premise, Padampura,
Chhatrapati Sambhajanagar 431005

E-mail address: westurangabad.ee@mahapwd.gov.in
Telephone/Fax Number :-0240 2331288
E-Tender Notice No.(67) of 2025-26

E-Tender for the following work in B-1 Tender Form is invited via online e- tendering system from Eligible Contractor by the Executive Engineer, Public Works (west) Division, Chhatrapati Sambhajanagar on behalf of Public Works Department, Government of Maharashtra Tender Document are downloaded from government portal <https://pwd.maharashtra.gov.in> Right to select or reject is reserved by Executive Engineer, Public Works (west) Division, Chhatrapati Sambhajanagar. Conditional Tender will be not accepted. (Number of 01 Works)

All information of e-tender is available on following portal.

A) <https://pwd.maharashtra.gov.in>

B) <https://mahatenders.gov.in>

If any change made in this e-tender is informed on above portal.

Sd/-Executive Engineer

Public Works (west) Division
Sambhajanagar

DGIPR/2025-2026/ 6768

NORTH CENTRAL RAILWAY

No. T_24-25, Upgrade

toilet RT, Date- 23.03.2026

Corrigendum

Corrigendum to Tender Notice No. T_24-25,

Upgrade, toilet RT, Date- 13.02.2026

Description- Tender Document- Upload Existing: TD Toilet05.pdf, **Modified Tender Document:** Tender Document Modified.pdf, Note:- All other terms and conditions remain the same. **345/26 FA**

www.northcentralrailways.gov.in

PUBLIC NOTICE

Under instructions from my client Sh. Gurdeep Singh S/o Late. Sh. Darshan Singh, R/o, 6/58, Geeta Colony, Gandhi Nagar, East Delhi- 110031, acting entirely out of his own free will, sound mind, and without any pressure. The General Public is hereby informed that after due deliberation, my client has irrevocably severed all relations with his daughter named Parleen Kaur Chawla, as she has continuously acted against his wishes and family values. He has permanently disowned and disbarred her from claiming any share in all his movable and immovable self-acquired properties. Anybody dealing with her shall do so at their own risk. My client shall not be responsible for any of her past, present, or future acts, deeds, or liabilities.

Ishtpreet Singh (Advocate)

Enroll. No. - D/13330/2025

Add:- H No.122, J and K Block, Laxmi Nagar, Delhi-110092

APPENDIX IV-A
Sale Notice for sale of Immovable Property
E-Auction Sale Notice for sale of Immovable Assets under the Securitisation and Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act, 2002 read with proviso to Rule 8(6) of the Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules, 2002
Notice is hereby given to the public in general and in particular to the Borrower(s) and Guarantor(s) that the below described Immovable Property mortgaged to Sammaan Capital Limited (formerly known as Indiabulls Housing Finance Ltd.) [CIN : L65922DL2005PLC136029] ("Secured Creditor"), the constructive possession of which has been taken by the Authorised Officer of the Secured Creditor, will be sold on "as is where is", "as is what is" and "whatever there is" basis on 27.04.2026 from 05.00 P.M. to 06.00 P.M., for recovery of Rs. 22,41,424/- (Rupees Twenty Two Lakh Forty One Thousand Four Hundred Twenty Four only) pending towards Loan Account No. HHNLNOD00416572, by way of outstanding principal, arrears (including accrued late charges) and interest till 16.03.2026 with applicable future interest in terms of the Loan Agreement and other related loan document(s) w. e. f. 17.03.2026 along with legal expenses and other charges due to the Secured Creditor. The Reserve Price of the Immovable Property will be Rs. 16,00,000/- (Rupees Sixteen Lakh only) and the Earnest Money Deposit ("EMD") will be Rs. 1,60,000/- (Rupees One Lakh Sixty Thousand only) i. e. equivalent to 10% of the Reserve Price.

RESIDENTIAL FLAT NO. - SF - 1, M. I. G. TYPE, SECOND FLOOR, (WITH ROOF RIGHTS), LEFT HAND FRONT SIDE, HAVING ITS TOTAL AND COVERED AREA MEASURING 550 SQ. FEET, I. E. 51.09 SQ. METRES, BUILT ON PLOT NO. C - 1/58, SITUATED AT DLF ANKUR VIHAR, VILLAGE SADULLABAD / LONI, PARGANA AND TEHSIL LONI, DISTRICT GHAZIABAD - 201010, UTTAR PRADESH.

For detailed terms and conditions of sale, please refer to the link provided on the website of the Secured Creditor i.e. www.sammaancapital.com. Contact No : 0124-69109 GAURAV KUMAR, ASHISH and KIRAN KUMAR. E-mail id : auctionhelpline@sammaancapital.com. For bidding, log on to www.auctionbazaar.com.

Date : 17.03.2026
Place : GHAZIABAD

AUTHORIZED OFFICER
SAMMAAN CAPITAL LIMITED (Formerly known as INDIABULLS HOUSING FINANCE LTD.)

UJVN LIMITED
H.O.: "UJJWAL", Maharani Bagh, G.M.S. Road, Dehradun-248006
Telephones: 0135-2763808, Fax: 0135-2763508
CIN No. U40101UR2001SGC025866 Website: www.ujvn.com

Letter No: 243 **Date Extension Notice** Date: 24/03/2026

Due to un avoidable reasons, the dates of the Tender No : 05/EE (Civil-IV)/LMP/2025-26 is hereby extended as follows:-
Name of work:-Operation of bank operated cable way-based Gauge and Discharge measurement site on river Yamuna for Lakhwar Multipurpose Project
Last date for submission of bids: 02-04-2026 upto 17:00 Hrs.
Date of opening of bids : 04-04-2026 at 11:00 Hrs.
Other terms & condition of tender will remain same. For fuller & further details, kindly visit "www.ujvn.com" **Executive Engineer (Civil-IV)**
Lakhwar Project Dakpathar, Dehradun

"AVOID WASTEFUL USE OF ELECTRICITY"

UJVN LIMITED
H.O.: "UJJWAL", Maharani Bagh, G.M.S. Road, Dehradun-248006
Telephones: 0135-2763808, Fax: 0135-2763508
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Date of opening of bids : 04-04-2026 at 11:00 Hrs.
Other terms & condition of tender will remain same. For fuller & further details, kindly visit "www.ujvn.com" **Executive Engineer (Civil-IV)**
Lakhwar Project Dakpathar, Dehradun

"AVOID WASTEFUL USE OF ELECTRICITY"

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

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I MISSED HIM A LOT: SAUMYA

Tandon got candid about Akshaye Khanna's absence in 'Dhurandhar 2: The Revenge'

Saumya Tandon played the role of Rehman Dakait's wife, Ulfath Rehman, in 'Dhurandhar'. The actress reprised her role in 'Dhurandhar: The Revenge', which saw director Aditya Dhar return with leading man Ranveer Singh. Amid the massive success of part two, she sent a shout-out to her on-screen husband, Akshaye Khanna, who wasn't a part of the sequel.

In an interview with 'Variety India', Saumya Tandon talked about her brief role in 'Dhurandhar: The Revenge'. The actress shared, "I actually don't have much to do in 'Dhurandhar 2'. There is a scene of mine that has gone viral, but I wouldn't like to speak about it because I think I'd like them to see the movie first."

The actress said that it was a very intense scene, which was during Rehman Dakait's funeral. Elaborating about the state of her character at the time, Saumya shared, "It's a very complicated scene because she's again very angry and also, she's kind of in a situation where she's questioning. And she's desperate."



The actress talked about her brief role in the sequel

She went on to add that for 'Dhurandhar' movies, everything had to be 'expressed with your eyes'.

In the same conversation, Saumya added that she missed Khanna's presence. She said, "Of course, as a viewer, I missed him a lot. He was so good in the first film. But then this is a story and it progresses after his death."

The film also stars Sanjay Dutt, Arjun Rampal, Rakesh Bedi, Sara Arjun and R Madhavan in leading roles. The star cast also includes Danish Pandor, Gaurav Gera, Saumya Tandon, Mustafa Ahmed, Danish Iqbal, Mohit Malik and others. The movie was released in theatres on March 19, 2026 and has already raked in over Rs 700 crore at the box office. AGENCIES

Kubbra opens up about her role in 'SANKALP'

Sait also talked about sharing the screen space with Nana Patekar in Amazon MX Player's series

OUR CORRESPONDENT

Amazon MX Player recently launched 'Sankalp', a gripping socio-political thriller that navigates the intricate intersections of power, mentorship and ideology. Directed by National Award-Winning filmmaker Prakash Jha and produced by 'PJP Productions' in partnership with 'Jio Studios', the series is headlined by Nana Patekar alongside a powerhouse cast featuring Mohammed Zeeshan Ayyub, Kubbra Sait, Neeraj Kabi, Sanjay Kapoor and Kranti Prakash Jha in pivotal roles.

Set against the backdrop of institutional influence and rising ambition, the series explores the evolving dynamics between mentor and mentee and how conviction, loyalty and authority shape those driven to lead and create change.

Reflecting on her character, Parveen, Kubbra Sait shared insight into the emotional and moral complexities of the role: "Parveen is raised within a very strong value system. In her world, only the destined or the truly gifted stand a chance of entering the system. But the battle between personal conscience and the system never really



The series has been directed by filmmaker Prakash Jha

disappears. What drew me to Parveen was her unwavering moral compass, despite the environment she's shaped by. She believes she can transform the system from within, but gradually realises that the system, in turn, begins to reshape her. That inner conflict made Parveen incredibly compelling for me to portray as an actor."

Speaking about her experience of working alongside the veteran actor Nana Patekar, Kubbra added, "I shared most of my scenes with Nana Saab, who is truly an institution himself. Acting alongside him felt like a masterclass every single day. What stayed with me was his discipline. He would meticulously handwrite all his lines and rehearse them before every scene. Watching someone of his stature approach the craft with that much sincerity was incredibly inspiring. Also, on a lighter note, Nana Sir might be the best cook ever - I would like to believe I come in a close second when it comes to biryani."

LOVE RETURNS TO THE LAKE

'Every Year After' reveals first look at a story of second chances

OUR CORRESPONDENT

Prime Video gave fans their first glimpse of the beloved Barry's Bay romance by revealing the first look images for 'Every Year After', the series based on Carley Fortune's best-selling novel 'Every Summer After'. The Amazon Original series will debut all episodes on June 10 with an eight-episode season.

Told over the course of six years and one week in Barry's Bay - the quintessential lake town - 'Every Year After' is a romantic, nostalgic story of first loves and the people and choices that mark us forever.

The series is based on the best-selling novel by Carley Fortune, 'Every Summer After' - which spent 16 weeks on the 'New York Times' bestseller list, has sold 1M+ copies to date



and gained popularity through 'BookTok' with the book hashtag getting over 81.4M views on 'TikTok'.

The series is told over the course of six years and one week in Barry's Bay. It is a romantic,

The 'Prime Video' series will debut all episodes on June 10 with an eight-episode season

nostalgic story of first loves and the next great YA series we think audiences will fall in love with.

'Every Year After' stars Sadie Soverrall and Matt Cornett as Percy and Sam, the couple at the centre of the love story. Additional cast members include Aurora Perrineau, Abigail Cowen, Michael Bradway, Joseph Chiu and Elisha Cuthbert.

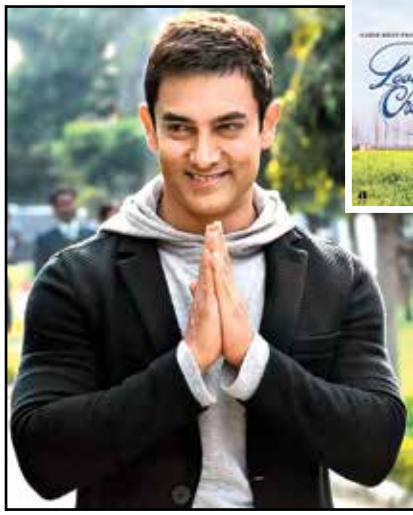
Amy B Harris will serve as showrunner and executive producer alongside Fortune, Lindsey Liberator, Amy Rardin, John Stephens and Grace Gilroy as executive producers.

Aamir Khan tears up over Laal Singh Chaddha's failure

Aamir Khan still hasn't been able to get over the failure of his 2022 film, Advait Chandra's 'Laal Singh Chaddha', an official remake of the 1994 Hollywood film 'Forrest Gump'. At the Indian Film Festival of Melbourne (IFFM) in Australia, the actor recalled how that setback was very different from the one that came before that - Vijay Krishna Acharya's 2018 period action adventure 'Thugs of Hindostan'.

"When 'Thugs...' didn't do well, I wasn't surprised because I didn't like it. So, the audience and I were on the same side, though I was sad because so much effort was put into it. Aditya Chopra had put in so much money. He's a great producer. He'd done so much for the film. And of course, we were all disappointed. But it was like an accident I could see happening in slow motion. But with 'Laal Singh Chaddha', I thought it was a very nice film. It's still a very good film," Aamir confessed.

When the live audience said that they lapped up the film, Aamir argued that most of them didn't show up in cinemas when it was first released back then. "While a number of



people have liked 'Laal Singh Chaddha', I'm also aware that a number of people really didn't get it. It'd be childish of me to try and believe otherwise," added Aamir. AGENCIES



Harshvardhan shares emotional note on working with John Abraham

Harshvardhan Rane expressed his gratitude for getting to work with John Abraham, calling himself a fan of the star and summed up his journey from being a delivery boy to working on set.

Rane uploaded a series of pictures on his 'Instagram' handle on Monday from the preparations for his next film, 'Force 3'. The first picture featured Rane standing at the backdrop of Abraham's poster, followed by a clapper board with 'Force 3' written over it.

"Working for the world's best producer @thejohnabraham... From being a delivery boy, his fan and now to be on his set," he wrote.

He added, "To all the delivery boys who dream, the rough streets will make you tough, the unreasonable delivery time will discipline



you, the heat will test your patience, the rain will challenge your spirits and the long riding hours will question your limits. You're not just delivering orders, you're building patience, hunger and resilience," he added.

Rane started shooting for 'Force 3', earlier this month. He announced the news with a post on his 'Instagram'

Rane uploaded a series of pictures on his 'Instagram' handle from the preparations for his next film 'Force 3'

handle. Written by Simaash Hashmi, the upcoming film is directed by Bhav Dhulia, known for 'Khakee: The Bihar Chapter'.

The 'Force' franchise started in 2011, featuring Abraham in the lead role. Directed by Nishikant Kamat, it also starred Genelia D'Souza alongside the actor and was a remake of the 2003 Tamil film 'Kaakha Kaakha'. The second instalment, led by Abraham, was released in 2016 and also featured Sonakshi Sinha. PTI

Akshay Kumar bets high on his new film 'Bhooth Bangla'

The Bollywood actor called Aditya Dhar's directed film 'Dhurandhar: The Revenge' a great film

MUMBAI: Bollywood superstar Akshay Kumar said 'Dhurandhar' is a great film that appeals to adults, while his upcoming film 'Bhooth Bangla' is for both children and families.

'Dhurandhar: The Revenge', the second part of Aditya Dhar's spy drama, featuring Ranveer Singh, has become a box office sensation since its release four days ago. It has already amassed Rs 761 crore at the box office and is expected to soon race past the figure of Rs 1,000 crore.

'Bhooth Bangla', a horror-comedy, releases in cinemas on April 10 and both Akshay and Priyadarshan have high hopes for the movie. When asked whether it was a conscious decision to bring out a light-hearted movie at a time when action and violent movies are ruling the box office, Akshay said their decision was not dictated by any trend.

"There are different kinds of films being made. 'Dhurandhar' is a great film. I've seen it. 'Bhooth Bangla' is a different film. 'Dhurandhar' is an adult film. 'Bhooth Bangla' is for kids and families. When we made this film, we didn't look at what the current trend is; we rather looked at whether the story was good or not and accordingly we made this film. We never thought



about the trend," Kumar told PTI. Priyadarshan, who has worked with Akshay on 'Hera Pheri', 'Garam Masala' and 'Bhool Bhulaiyya', said audience flocking to watch 'Border 2' and 'Dhurandhar', will need a break. "Films like 'Dhurandhar', 'Border 2', all are doing extremely well and all of a sudden, when you take a break and do something different and great. People who watch films like 'Dhurandhar' can also enjoy it," he said.

Priyadarshan said the 'area of exploitation' is larger in such movies than that of action films because it appeals to a universal audience. "I think our area of exploitation is bigger and people like to see dif-

ferent things. That is our biggest plus point with 'Bhooth Bangla'. Moreover, this is a pure entertainment and a fun film; it isn't as intense as 'Border' or 'Dhurandhar'. People enjoy every kind of film. I believe as long as the film is holding the attention and

'Bhooth Bangla', a horror-comedy, will release in cinemas on April 10

interest of people, every film will work."

Presented by 'Balaji Motion Pictures', a division of 'Balaji Telefilms Ltd', in association with 'Cape of Good Films', the film is produced by Akshay Kumar, Shobha Kapoor and Ekta R Kapoor. PTI

